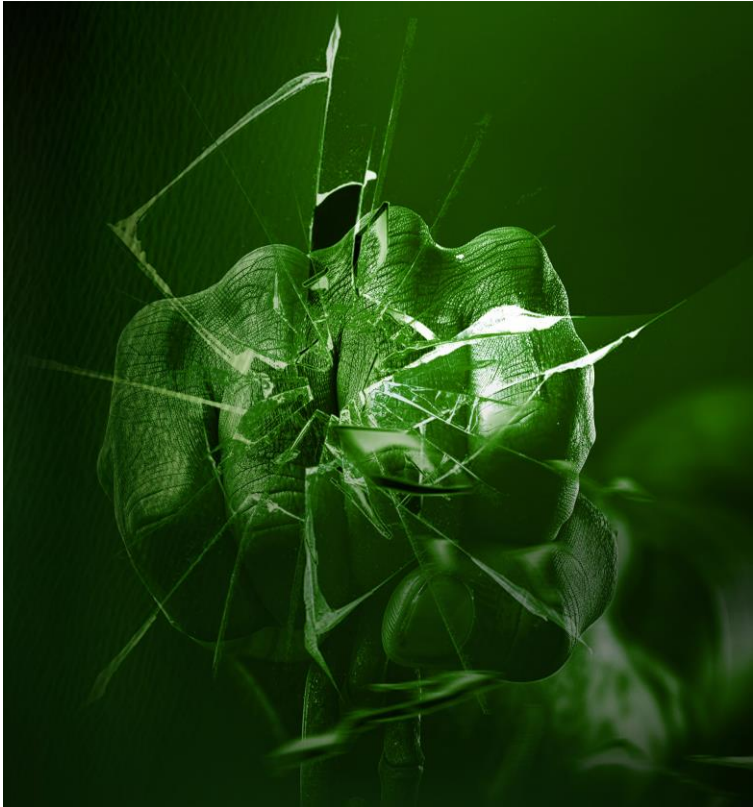


A close-up photograph of a green lotus flower in bloom, set against a dark background. The flower is partially obscured by numerous sharp, translucent shards of broken glass that appear to be shattering outwards from its center, creating a dramatic and symbolic visual.

BREAKING THE GLASS CEILING

A N I N S I D E R M E M O I R

ANTHONY TSE

**BREAKING
THE
GLASS CEILING**
An Insider Memoir

Anthony Tse

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INTRODUCTION

Many people in our world today are caught up in the endless pursuit of happiness. We all want to do something meaningful in life. Most people would defend the pursuit of their dreams. But the truth is, are we really happy? Are our jobs meaningful? Are we working towards our dreams? I have had to do my fair share of striving for gold and hustling to make my impact in life — starting from my early days as an immigrant in the US to my emergence into the world of finance and ultimately entrepreneurship. It's safe to say that life has served me my fair share of curve balls and I say this not to complain but rather in gratitude. The challenges I have encountered from my early days of humble beginnings till date have been nothing short of inspirational.

When I set out to write this book, it was mainly because I felt it was one many people can relate to. The main reason is because this is just a story about an ordinary guy from humble beginning and how he fights against all odds to achieve

certain milestones in life. This could be your story. In fact, it could be anybody's. I've always believed that the life you get is actually what you choose to make out of it - consciously or subconsciously. It all depends on your outlook on life and how you interpret the circumstances by which you're surrounded. There would always be the good times and bad times. Sometimes you win some, sometimes you lose some. This is just what life is about and if you decide not to step out, take some calculated risk, embrace discomfort and attempt to live your dream life; chances are that you would end up with a truckload of "what-ifs" or regrets even as you advance in life. You've got to look past today and think long term. That way you'll be able to secure an enviable future.

This memoir promises to be many things, but one thing it doesn't promise to be is a washed-up and phoney motivational book. I wouldn't tell you a perfect story because my story isn't perfect. The beauty in the painting of my life can be found in the seemingly flawed edges. I feel like deep down, we are all ordinary people,

striving to play our part in the circle of life. But to that, I have one preliminary advice — why not break out of the circle? My proudest moments come from my desire to do the things outside of the circle which most people didn't have the courage to do. I believe this a secret ingredient to freedom — your freedom. So, let's begin!

CHAPTER ONE

From Humble Beginnings

I was born in Hong Kong to a middle-class family, but I knew that my parent's didn't have the best life growing up. My early life saw me spend a great deal of time around my paternal grandmother who always told me stories about my dad and the kind of life he had growing up. My father was born in farming village in southern China, and he would later move to Hong Kong when he was still in primary school. My grandfather and my dad's brother remained in the village for more than two more decades because at the time, only one person in the family was allowed to go to Hong Kong. It is fair to say that I come from a lineage of local farmers because that was the heritage I had with me being the first generation to be born outside a village but rather in the mega and modern city of Hong Kong.

Life on the farm was simple yet fulfilling. Each morning, my father would join his parents

and sibling in the fields, their hands coated with earth as they worked the soil. They planted seeds with care, nurturing each tiny sprout as it reached towards the sky. From dawn until dusk, they toiled under the watchful eye of the sun. And at the end of the day, a fruitful yield was their reward. They tended cows, pigs and fished in our ancestral pond. One thing rearing livestock would teach you is how to care for something other than yourself. It was a fulltime job with no days off. The livestock we reared served as a form of income while the rest provided a reliable source of meat and dairy. My father and his relatives would share the experience of Great Leap Forward during which they would basically eat anything that moved – rodents and insects. Every time I observe the elders reminisce on these experiences; I only see laughter on their faces because these memories reminded them of how far they have progressed despite all the vicissitudes of life.

This is how the generation before me lived. They had to endure days of blistering heat and torrential rain, where the earth seemed to

rebel against their efforts. But through hardship came resilience, and they weathered each storm with unwavering resolve. They knew that nature was both friend and foe and that their bond with the land was as enduring as the roots that anchored their crops. Later in life, the lessons of seed time and harvest would guide me to success. Farming wasn't the only heritage my family had; they were also hardworking and resilient.

With the unsteady income that an agrarian life provided, it was high time they found an alternative. My grandmother had been a domestic helper for a large family in Hong Kong for thirty years while working multiple side jobs and that's how she was able to raise enough money to care for dad and family back in the village in China. I grew up hearing tales of how much she sacrificed to provide for her family. My dad wasn't born with a silver spoon in his mouth. Finishing high school was the end of the road of his academic journey. My dad had to work because he needed to help pay the bills. Either he got busy, or the family suffered severe hardship. My dad studied in a religious boarding school

and summer break would usually be a time of revelry for students to go home and play. For dad, summer was stressful. He had no home to go to because he couldn't stay at the employer's abode where my grandmother was the live-in domestic helper. He was a nomad, crashing at friends or shophouses. These are the stories that shaped my life. One thing I learned from the last generation was that they had to carve out a life for themselves in the toughest of times and harsh circumstances. It's not about how much resources one has, but how resourceful one is. I knew that I would be a fool not to take advantage of the opportunities life had given me. If they could achieve what they did with the little resources at their disposal, then I had zero excuses. I made up my mind to fight and take advantage of every opportunity I had at my disposal.

In the early 80s, China was still very poor. My earliest recollection of the village was at four years old when we would leave the big city and visit the village which was still underdeveloped. People were poor and mostly struggled to have

access to a proper meal or running water. I remember the well and the bucket outside the house because I was scared to look down. Just bringing back household items such as toothpaste, toothbrushes and snacks made us look like celebrities. I was quite young, so these are vague memories that influenced my mindset while growing up.

Growing up in the City of Hong Kong gave me access to the better side of life. Life in Hong Kong in the 1980s was characterized by rapid economic growth, industrialization, and urbanization. The city was a bustling hub of trade and commerce, with a growing financial sector. The culture was a mix of traditional Chinese customs and modern Western influences, reflecting the city's status as a global metropolis. However, there were also social and political tensions, as the handover of Hong Kong from British colonial rule to Chinese sovereignty approached. The 1980s saw the first wave of mass immigration. Even in the midst of this, I can say that I had a pretty normal childhood. My sister and I often played outdoor games and had a ton of fun. Little did I know that

my life was set for a tailspin? I noticed that I would run out of breath fairly quickly and my lips would turn purple every time I swam. My parents took me to the hospital to run a medical diagnosis and when the test results finally came out, we were greeted with the sad news that I had a congenital heart defect. My parents didn't show it, but I knew they were scared for my life. Between trying to wrap their minds around why a perfectly healthy five-year-old kid would have a heart condition and the financial burden of footing the bills, my parents gave me all the support they could muster. The doctor said the only solution was to undergo open heart surgery. Days blurred into weeks, marked by consultations and tests. Fear hung heavy in the air as we approached the operating room months later. Yet, amidst trepidation, I had this feeling deep inside that everything would be okay.

The surgery passed in a blur — a blur of lights and masked faces. But through it all, my family and loved ones believed in the saying that “this too would pass” and that I would be healthy again. And true to their belief, the surgery was a

success. Over the next six months of my life, I steadily recovered and became healthy again although school had to be put on hold for the duration of my recovery. The road to my recovery was smooth and quick because I had an amazing family. They did everything for me just to make sure I was okay. But something still bothered me. Yes, I was happy with all the attention I was getting but I didn't want to be treated like some fragile glassware that could fall apart at the slightest pressure. I wanted to run, jump and have fun like any normal kid would, but I couldn't quite do that. The doctor had given strict instructions for me to take things slow, especially in my childhood years. It took a while, but I fully recovered, and my heart got stronger. Another thing that got stronger was my resolve and resilience. I knew I could beat all odds and surmount any obstacle. I constantly asked myself "why did I have to go through this and not others?" It was then that I subconsciously came to terms that I am just different. Thankfully, almost 40 years later I am energetic and healthy.

Why Finance?

As a child, I wouldn't say my father was always around, but I could boldly say that a few of the most pivotal and life-changing moments of my life were from the few times I spent with him, and this begins the story of why I decided to enter the world of finance. It was on one of those rare occasions when I sat down to have a chat with my dad that he asked the question, "What do you want to be when you grow up Son? You should always plan at least five years ahead" My response was, "I really don't know." I knew the stereotypical response that kids my age would give like; I want to be a doctor, a policeman, a fire-fighter or even an astronaut. But even as a kid, I wasn't one to follow the crowd's mentality and that's why I gave my honest response. My dad began to tell me about Wall Street and the world of finance. He knew things beyond what a person of his academic level was expected to know, and this is credited to his unquenchable thirst for knowledge (a habit I would later pick up from him) either by reading or interacting with highly capable people. He said, "Son, money begets money (钱生钱)", a statement I would never forget. I was

very young at the time, and I didn't understand what that meant. He went on to explain to me the disadvantage of earning on an hourly basis, which is what he had done. We all get twenty-four hours in a day, within which we would have to eat, sleep, relate with our loved ones and do other recreational stuff if we so choose. In a nutshell, we have a limited number of hours within which we can work and play. But if I wanted to have more time to play than others, than I should consider finance. These two pieces of sage-like advice from my dad were the foundational reasons why I chose to venture into the world of finance. It was never about the fame and the materialism, but finance appeared to be a game where money can grow like a tree, and as the tree grows, I can have more freedom to play more. This seemed like the most exciting game one can ever play! Even as I grew up, many things strengthened my convictions, and we'll get to the juicy bits later.

The American Dream

The phrase, "The American Dream" became increasingly popular in 1931 by Walter

Lippmann's 1914 Drift and Mastery. This was also the driving force behind the immigration boom that saw an influx of immigrants from around the world in search of greener pastures and better economic opportunities. The greatest allure in the gospel of the American dream was that regardless of who you are and where you're from, you had an equal opportunity to achieve your highest potential and live your best life if you work hard and have the will to succeed.

But I soon realized that the American dream wasn't as dreamy as they said it would be. No one would give you handouts and dollar notes didn't grow on trees. We faced our fair share of struggles as an immigrant family. I had to learn English for the sake of going to school. My parents tried to put me in a private school, so we went for interviews, but for each interview we attended, I got slammed with rejection. I was repeatedly told that my English was not good and that if I would be sincere with myself, my English sucked. I barely knew any English and resorted to a public school where English proficiency wasn't a prerequisite. Here I would have to

undergo a program called, “English as a Second Language.” This lasted for three years and at the end of this, my English significantly improved. Who would have expected that years later I would end up speaking four languages?

All these things happened to me before I reached the age of ten. Sometimes when I look back at the first ten years of my life, I marvel at the things I went through. I didn’t have the privilege of having the life of an average kid. First, it was my heart condition and then the struggles of surviving in a new country. There were times I would be bullied and at other times I would get into fights and get my ass kicked. I had gone home up a few times with a bruised nose. But instead of becoming a cry-baby or throwing a pity party for myself, I developed grit and resilience. I knew my background put me at a disadvantage and I would need to work harder than everyone else. I remember the time I had to take the Golden State Exam in elementary school and scored 28%. This simply meant that 72% of students scored better than I did. I must have been the only Asian who failed math because I

just didn't understand the word problems. So, when other students would study for an hour, I had to study for at least four hours just to level the playing field. You know, to narrow the gap and give me a fighting chance of surviving, not to mention succeeding. This was the new normal for me. Surrounded by a host of uncertainties, life had begun to teach me invaluable lessons, but nothing could have prepared me well enough for the things that would happen in the next decade of my life.

CHAPTER TWO

A Gift from God

Life began to open up to me at age ten.

I had finished my ESL program, and I would soon be able to take classes like a regular kid. Within a year, I started taking honors classes which are more difficult than regular classes. But there was no magical mystery to my supersonic academic progress. It was simply hard work. In a little over a decade, I would begin to apply this principle as I launched into the world of finance. I knew that this was the only way to compensate for my slow academic start, language deficiency and my inexperience. I could learn from the lessons from my father's life. When he moved from China to Hong Kong he was very behind academically. He was demoted from fifth grade to third grade. He is a highly intelligent person, but external factors or "ovarian lottery" that he had no control over set him back in a new environment. He worked extra hard and soon became one of the top students in his class. He joked about how at swim

meets, despite being physically the strongest as he was two years older than his classmates, he would swim doggy style and come in last because he never had formal coaching while his peers all had instructors. Spectators would laugh, but he still finished. With this story, I knew that every obstacle could be overcome if you are ready to put in the work and learn.

Saved Behind the Wheels

Many events have shaped my life, but this event not only shaped my life but saved me. I literally received a second chance at life! I started to drive independently on the day I turned sixteen. I didn't know that I would soon dread cruising on my beloved wheels until the day one of my buddies got involved in a ghastly accident. He was driving beside me, lost control and crashed into a tree. It all seemed to happen in a second. I watched my friend die before my very eyes. The passenger, also my friend, was in critical condition for weeks. I, and the two passengers in my car, would have been crushed as well but for a split-second miracle that saw me swerve out of the way just in time to avoid the

fatal collision. I made a U-turn back to the scene, sat still in my car, as my body shivered with trepidation and my skin exploded with goose bumps. A barrage of thoughts rammed at the gate of my mind like battering rams. “It could have been me, and with just a few blinks, my friend is gone.” Paramedics came and I, along with my two passengers, was taken to the police station for investigation.

I met the parents of my deceased friend who wanted me to recount the details of the accident. They were very kind and lovely parents. They didn’t blame me for what happened. They said to me, “There is nothing we can do to bring him back, but we just want to know what happened.” They somberly concluded with “He’s gone now at 16 and you have to live his life for him.”

I remember going to my friend’s funeral and gosh, it was hard to believe that he was gone just like that. Come on, we were just sixteen and our lives had barely begun. But just like the proverbial phoenix, I was left with the feeling that I had been graciously given a second chance

at life - one I was tremendously grateful for. Weeks following the tragic accident, I went around my high school and gave speeches about my experience and that while we think we are invincible, we are not. Every time I gave those speeches, I would break down and cry in front of my classmates. I wrote an article sharing that my biggest learning lesson from this incident is not to live with regret asking “what if “because you never know if today would be your last day.

In my mind, striving for the best and reaching for the stars was no longer a debate. My parents had sacrificed so much to give me a better life and now I got saved from an untimely death. Not making something out of my life would be the loudest statement of ingratitude. To this day, whenever I go back to my hometown, I try to visit my friend’s grave and thank him and God for letting me walk away alive on that day in 1996.

College Seasons Caper

I tried to put aside the incident that almost claimed my life and tried to re-focus on High School. The memories are still fresh in my head

— the taste of cafeteria food, melodramatic hallway gossip, and the daunting prospect of college applications looming over us like a storm cloud ready to burst. If there's one thing that binds us all in this chaotic journey, it's the absurdity of the college application process.

The caper among high school seniors during college season is crazy. You can feel the buzz in the atmosphere coupled with the collective panic of seniors scrambling to meet application deadlines. My classmates could be found pacing their rooms, in disarray, muttering about SAT scores and personal statements. People get so finicky, fearing that their extracurricular activities won't impress anyone. But even with all the chaos, there was a glimmer of hope — or should I say a glimmer of sheer madness. Leave it to us, the sleep-deprived, caffeine-fueled high *schoolers*, to turn the mundane task of college applications into a full-blown comedic spectacle.

During my time at high school, we had to accompany our college application with well-thought-out essays, and the serious ones among us would search for the best words to convey that we were the best candidate. Then we would have college visits, where we attempt to impress

admissions officers with our impeccable manners and vast knowledge of campus trivia. Little did they know we'd memorized the campus map solely to avoid getting lost on our way to the admissions office — a feat worthy of a gold star in survival skills, if you ask me. But what students feared the most was the requirement of getting letters of recommendation. Suddenly, every teacher becomes a potential ally in our quest for higher education, and we find ourselves shamelessly buttering them with phony comments (but I didn't do that.)

Surrounded by stressed-out teenagers armed with No. 2 pencils and calculators, poised to tackle the SAT I and SAT II, I made up my mind to not run the same rat race. I had to find out what students who got into the best colleges did and follow their process.

I found out that a couple of things influence the college choices of high school students. For some, it is the allure of the big names like Harvard, Princeton, Yale or Stanford. I once had a friend who was all about joining a college fraternity. He would yap endlessly about how “in there” these guys were — in his mind, being a frat boy meant endless access to hot girls and booze. But for me

it was different. I wanted to go to a school that offered the best finance programs, so I embarked on in-depth research and finally arrived at my best option — the Huntsman Program at the University of Pennsylvania. I discovered that they had a faculty loaded with great scholars and holistic curriculum. I would be learning from the very best should I get admitted. Then there was the networking edge of Penn's strategic location, the historic city of Philadelphia and access to Wall Street. I could see the surplus of opportunities to study abroad, international internships, and global research initiatives, and to top it up, I would be getting valuable hands-on experience in finance.

All I now needed to do was to craft myself to be that one student so irresistible the University would be on their toes to admit me. Right, much easier said than done. Nevertheless, I did what any serious student would do. I closely examined the lives of other students who got admitted to Penn and other Ivies in the past. Back in the mid-90s, internet was not the place to turn to, so I had to go the old-fashioned way of asking questions, reading publications and college magazines and talking to my high school teachers. I studied the

profile of successful candidates who got admitted before me. I took as many advanced classes as possible, anything to increase my chances of getting admitted. I am fortunate to have an older sister who applied to college 3 years before I did, so I could learn from her.

When I received the news that I had been admitted I couldn't believe it. My ears tingled with excitement and my heart was bursting in joy. This son of a farm boy had come a long way, and I was on my way to my dream university. As I cried tears of joy, I knew deep in my heart this was both luck and dedication. I couldn't boast of being the smartest kid on the block because I know I am not, but I had worked my ass off for this. I had found the way — my secret life hack — work harder than everyone around you or in the least, outwork yourself every day, strive to be the best that you can be and then incessantly model after those who have been there and done that. The secret is in having a goal that inspires you to keep pushing. One day, luck will come, and I will be there to grab it. Getting into a great college had been my goal and I worked really hard all through my high school days. I set a plan in motion early on to achieve my goals. A

mediocre plan is better than no plan. So, after doing all I could, I kept my fingers crossed and hoped for the best.

CHAPTER THREE

Working Harder

I had a mindset about life and that is “The things you did to get to the next level are the same things you must keep doing to keep forging ahead”, and I dare say, even more. Often people tend to rest on their laurels after attaining their goal or hitting a major milestone in life. I once heard someone say, “The greatest enemy to your future success is your present success.” With this knowledge I knew that getting into college was only the beginning. And yes, all my additional work paid off, and I got admitted into the University of Pennsylvania. The joy I felt was boundless because deep inside I knew I had luck. Even more surprising was I got admitted into my dream program. When I saw the caliber of my classmates, I was like boy, was I lucky! I was acutely aware I had one of the lowest, if not the lowest, standardized test score and GPA in my program. But I made up my mind to make the best use of this opportunity. I would need to be at my best to not fail.

Why Work?

My work journey began at the age of 15 when I took up a job as a part time teller at First Interstate Bank which was subsequently acquired by Wells Fargo. Every day, I would process transactions and count money. I was fast at counting money. On the surface the job looked simple and transactional but then it trained me to focus because if I lost concentration even for a short moment, then you can be sure an error would slip in. At the end of the day, I had to close my counter and ensure my cash balance was accurate to the penny. While that was stressful, what's worse is customer service. It was awkward dealing with strangers, greet them and learn that "customer is always right." I went through 2 weeks of customer service training at headquarters before I could start work. As I realize now the most valuable part of any job is to deal with people, I was so fortunate I had formal training at such a young age.

So, from the get-go, I've always had a work mindset. I've always believed in the saying that when the purpose of a thing is unknown, abuse is inevitable. This also applies to the concept of work, and I was lucky to not only have role models

who mirrored what it meant to be hardworking and resilient, but I was shown the reason why we are to work hard.

When we're young, we're full of energy and we feel like we can do a lot of things. That's the best time to learn about hard work and build good work ethics. Watching my parents work hard every day, I learned that it's not just about getting things done; it's about showing that you can keep going, even when things get tough.

But I often wondered, why work so hard? What's the point of putting in all this effort? For me, it's not just about money or acquiring material things. It's about something deeper, something that lasts longer than what we can see or touch.

Using sports as an analogy, every successful athlete will tell you they trained hard to get to where they are. Athletes will never tell you they excelled in their sport merely because they were just more talented than others. Training hard is about serving the tennis ball at 130mph and then training even harder and smarter so you can serve at 131mph consistently without injuring yourself. If an athlete overworks himself and gets injured, then that hard work is futile.

Study Hard

As I mentioned earlier, I am not the brightest kid on the block, but my life changed when I discovered the mystery of hard work. Intelligence is a gift, but hard work is a choice that anyone can make. I call it a mystery because despite how simple it is, many still grapple with it. Many of my peers were super intelligent valedictorians with perfect to almost perfect standardized test scores in high school. However, some were lazy in college, skipped classes, procrastinated, didn't turn in assignments nor prepare for exams. They failed. For the first time in their lives, not only did they not get A's, but D's and F's. This is because every competitor was intelligent, and IQ was no longer the only differentiating factor. Yet I had peers who never prepared for an exam and only opened the book the day before the exam and still got A's whereas for me, I would need to do all the practice problems available, not once, not twice, but thrice. And even after all that, I still scored below many. That didn't despair me. Instead, that made me realize the importance of hard work just to stay in the game.

Insanity has often been defined as doing the same thing while expecting a different result. And it's depressing that this is what most folks do these days. They want better grades, more money, valuable relationships, you name it, but that's all there is to it — wants. The one thing most people shy away from is putting in the work. It is what I would like to call a "Lottery mindset"— holding on to an expectation of the elusive big break that would never really happen. I realized one thing in life and that is you don't have to be a genius to be special. Some people are born with remarkably high IQs and way to go, I have much respect for such folks. But then others had to work at cultivating the resources they had until it became something truly special. It is the age-long battle between talent and hard work, but then I am tempted to ask, "Must there be a battle between the two?" Life would be so much simpler if they both worked hand in hand. A hardworking person would over time rival his talented counterpart who doesn't put in the work. So, without a doubt, I knew this was my secret weapon. The moment I realized that the number of courses I took didn't increase my tuition; I began taking as many courses as I could, so I took six classes a semester while the

norm was four. I graduated with 2 majors and 2 concentrations a semester early. This would work to my advantage years later. It broadened my knowledge span and boosted my critical thinking game — an indispensable tool in the workforce. More importantly, the semester I saved in college gave me time to do something meaningful, which I will share later.

Working as a College Student

My work journey continued till my days at Penn. At some point, I found myself juggling more than just textbooks and lectures. It was time for me to do something new and challenging so I took up a job as an entry-level accountant at a boutique law firm in downtown Philadelphia. For me, it wasn't really about the money, but I wanted to get more hands-on experience. On my first day at work, I noticed it was a small firm, but it was filled with elegant dark mahogany wood. The walls of the firm were adorned with intricate paintings, and the ambience exuded an air of calmness and sophistication. I saw a lot of legalese on the walls, but to be sincere I couldn't understand most of it.

My supervisor was a short man with dark eyes. His name was Johnson, but people called him Big John. He greeted me with a welcoming smile. "You'll be handling data entry for the accounts department. It's not glamorous work, but it's essential." Was I hyped about it? No. I wanted something more hard-core and finance related. I didn't attend an Ivy League just to do data entry, but this was what I was served so I decided to make lemonade out of my lemons.

Days turned into weeks, and I found myself immersed in my job. I started to understand that my role was essential for lawyers to bill their clients correctly. It was crucial as the foundation to generating financial reports, which was what I was most excited about. Nevertheless, I learned to appreciate that something that does not appear glamorous on the surface can also be tremendously valuable if you look at the bigger picture. I could see how lemons were being turned into lemonade.

Finding the Balance

However, as the workload at the firm increased, so did the demands of my academic life. Balancing work, studies and extracurricular

activities became a delicate tightrope act. I was literally running on empty at this point. Things began to fall apart. I was being paid \$15 per hour for my services and as a college student back then that was a lot but even that could not act as a motivation anymore. One evening, as I sat hunched over my textbooks, exhaustion gnawed at the edges of my consciousness. The deadlines loomed ominously, casting shadows of doubt upon my ability to keep up. “Anthony, you seem preoccupied,” Helen said. Now I have not spoken much about Helen, but she was one of the greatest pillars of support all through my college days. Her face wore a little frown, her eyebrows arched around the edges as the word, “concern” could be seen written all over her demeanour. I had changed greatly in the past few months. First, I was always cranky, thanks to my insanely tight schedule — my sleep-deprived mind was finding it hard to assimilate anything. I could have simply told Helen I was fine and that she was worrying about nothing, but I didn’t.

“I’m struggling to juggle everything. Work, school...it’s all becoming overwhelming.” Helen nodded empathetically; her eyes full of understanding. She sat with me for about half an

hour as I bore my heart out to her and within all that time, I never got any judgemental vibes from her. She didn't try to give me some groundbreaking advice. She just sat down and listened. At the end of it all she said, "Anthony, I know you have a good thing going with this job and all but not at the expense of enjoying your college experience."

Her words lingered in the air, and deep within me I knew that she was right. With renewed determination, I sought out the support I needed, whether it was from my colleagues at work or professors at university. Slowly but surely, I began to find my balance, navigating the tumultuous waters with newfound resilience. I learned to prioritize tasks, carving out pockets of time for both work and study.

And as the days turned into months, I discovered a sense of fulfilment in the harmony of my dual roles. The once daunting abyss of uncertainty now felt like a vast expanse of opportunity, waiting to be explored. At the time I didn't know it, but Helen was an incredible coach.

Play Hard

All through my life till now, I've reaped the benefits of hard-work, and I don't think I would have amounted to anything without it. It takes a lot to work hard. It's like the combination of different qualities; discipline, consistency, being present, attention to detail and perseverance. I've had to engage these qualities from the very beginning of my academic journey when I was learning English up till now.

But here's the thing: all work and no play makes life dull. My father wasn't so educated but there is something he taught me that has shaped my life so far. He taught me to "work hard and play even harder." I was taught this when I was young. So, what I would do is I would focus on the task I have at hand and execute it masterfully so that I could feel confident to play and let my hair down in between my work schedule. I know I'm all about working hard but you must also be as intentional about playing even harder.

Playing hard means taking time to enjoy yourself and recharge your batteries. It's not just about goofing off; it's about keeping yourself happy and healthy.

I learned that balance is key to maximizing your college experience. When I work hard during the week, I earn the chance to have fun on the weekends. Whether it's hanging out with friends, exploring Philly, or pursuing my hobbies, those moments of relaxation are just as important as hitting the books.

Another secret for finding work and play balance is to regulate your sleep. We all get 24 hours every day, so it all boils down to time management. I learned to sleep less, and I'm not saying to be sleep-deprived (because this could be counterproductive) but I didn't sleep like there was no tomorrow. Tony Robbins would often say, "Life is not all about work, but it is about maintaining a peak state." For me, this meant that when I was working, I had a zero-distraction policy and when I was playing, I played like a Pro. When I partied, I partied like there was no tomorrow. Despite my heart condition, I've always appreciated competitive sports as it has always been a way for me to relax and recharge my batteries. Do whatever works best for you. There is nothing like some good physical activity to get your juices flowing.

By working hard and playing hard, I get the best of both worlds. I could chase my goals while still making time for the things I love. And you know what? It makes me a happier, healthier and more balanced person overall.

Remember that life is more than just working. It's about having physical health, mental health, spiritual health, intellectual health and financial health. So, whether I was studying for exams or kicking back with friends, I always tried to maintain the balance between work and play.

The Huntsman Program

Ever had one of those crazy dreams that you never thought could ever come true? I was not just having a crazy dream; I was living in one when I got selected to join the Huntsman program, a dual degree business and liberal arts program that is second to none in the world. One thing I am super thankful for is having an older sister who was three and half years older than me. When I was entering high school as a freshman, she was in her final year of high school. Thus, a lot of what she had done I was able to use as samples. Things like taking advanced classes or college applications were not

novel to me. I wouldn't have known nor had any interest in the Huntsman program had my sister not applied for it years before I did. She wasn't just any older sister. She rolled out the carpet for me.

The Huntsman Program wasn't just any college program; it was a blend of international studies and business, offering a unique opportunity to explore the world. I knew it would be a challenge, but I was eager to dive in.

From day one, the diversity of the program struck me. I found myself surrounded by students from around the globe. We were 37 in total, each of us bringing our perspectives and stories to the table. It was like a mini - United Nations in our dormitory, and I loved it. We shared ideas, debated fiercely, and learned from each other in ways textbooks couldn't teach.

These were the valedictorians, perfect SAT scorers, concert pianist and polyglots. People with such astronomically good grades would make your legs feel like spaghetti. I'm talking about top scholars in the country they came from. I often asked myself how a person who immigrated to the US and couldn't even speak

English until the age of ten found himself among these people. More than two decades later, I still question such miracle. But guess what? Some of my classmates were also immigrants who had much more humble backgrounds than I did. Again, there is nothing special about me. Absolutely nothing. I held on to the thought that if I got lazy, I'd sink faster than an anchor in the deep blue sea. I need to focus.

The program was for Scholars (that was definitely not me) but the real magic happened beyond the classroom walls. The Huntsman Program took us on adventures around the world. From the bustling streets of Beijing to the charming cafes of Paris, we immersed ourselves in different cultures, languages, and business practices. Study abroad was like a crash course in global understanding, and I soaked it all in like a sponge.

Of course, it wasn't all smooth sailing. There were late nights of studying, moments of doubt, and papers that seemed never-ending. Balancing academics with exploration wasn't easy, but it was worth it. Those challenges pushed me to grow, to think critically, and to persevere when things got tough.

What kept me going, though, was the community. The Huntsman Program wasn't just a collection of students; it was a family. We supported each other through thick and thin, celebrating victories and lifting each other during setbacks. Whether it was studying together in the library or sharing a meal after a long day of classes, I knew I was never alone. Twenty plus years out, we are still a close-knit community.

Grades is Just One Data Point

In academic institutions around the globe, there's intense debate about whether good grades really matter. Some say they're just about how well one memorizes, not real smarts. But I'm here to say that good grade is an important data point. Grades are powerful indices available to every student to distinguish themselves. A student can choose to distinguish himself in a good way or in a bad way. And as much as there are a bunch of things that influence the grades people get, I still believe we are the architects of our destiny. I feel I can boldly say this because of the challenges I had to surmount in life.

There are other facts people neglect when dissecting the subject of grades. I grew up with the mindset that the grades you get in school are a revelation of how hard you've worked, how you've managed your time, and how much you really care about learning. Getting good grades means; putting in the effort, staying focused, and wanting to understand things deeply. If you're like that then that's great. Your mindset of excellence would be a plus wherever you go in life. But then if the only thing you know is how to get good grades, then you'll struggle to shine in the real world. It's possible to master the art of answering questions and doing project with smarts and impeccable intelligence. The body of knowledge we interact with as students is often static but in the real world, you'll be rated by how adaptable you are and your ability to think outside the box.

I believe that those who are solely good in grades tend to underachieve in life. because they were not trained to commit mistakes, take risks or fail. They think getting a B is the end of the world. One thing I did during my college days was taking on many tasks that were not academics related for me to meet high-achieving students with other

interests and personalities. That was the highlight of my college experience.

While good grades are important, they're not everything. School is about more than just getting A's. It's about learning new things, exploring what you're passionate about, and growing as a person.

So, as you go through school, remember that good grades are one of the many splits in a long-distance race. Each split is a useful indicator of how you will finish your marathon. And if you train hard to shave a second off each split, then one day you can be a winner. Grades show how hard you've worked, how much you've learned and how much you have progressed. But don't forget to enjoy the journey and observe the beautiful surrounding while running this marathon and recording your splits. With improving grades and a curious mind, you can go far.

The Symphony Orchestra

There are many things I like to do but one of my low-key passions is music. I was in the Penn Symphony Orchestra from 1997 to 2001 and was the Vice President. Like most Asians, my parents

wanted me to pick up an instrument and my instrument of choice was the violin. Also, when I studied abroad in Beijing at Tsinghua University, I joined its Orchestra and got to meet amazing new people.

My training in music began from my early days. While my peers spent time listening to pop, rock or rhythm and blues, I had developed an affinity for classical music, the Beethoven's, Bach's, Tchaikovsky's and singing Cantopop. The feeling was like the world was spinning in a spiral motion. It was the sparkle of a million light bulbs in my little mind. I knew music wasn't a career path for me, but it helped me see the world differently. Music was more than a muse for me. I could tap into deeper layers of creativity that I didn't know existed within me.

Studying finance and being a violinist created this weird duality. On weekdays, I was crunching numbers and stressing about grades. But come the weekend rehearsals, I was in a different world — the world where the only numbers that mattered were the beats per minute. My classmate across my hallway was an Oboist and I would hear him practice in his room. I became friends with the cellist, Emily, who was majoring

in biochemistry. We'd swap notes about bonds and molecules during breaks, but when the conductor raised his baton, everything else faded away. It was like having a clandestine life, and I loved it.

Performing in the university's Irvine Auditorium was nerve-wracking. The crowd, the lights, the fancy outfits – it was a far cry from my usual finance lectures. But when we started playing, I forgot about the tuxedo. The music carried me, and for those moments, I was free from the worries of group projects and excel models. The orchestra unlocked a dimension of my hidden appreciation for life.

The day the idea came into my mind about a cross-culture symphony was when I was rehearsing with the Tsinghua Orchestra. I knew it was beyond the musings of my mind, and I knew it was something great waiting to happen. It was my brainchild, and I would tend to it to see that it became a reality. I shared the idea with the Music Director after my study abroad and he loved every bit of it. At first, I was scared to tell him because I felt he would see my idea as being too unconventional. But I thought to myself, isn't that the idea of creativity-always breaks the limits of

conventionality? After studying abroad in Beijing, I noticed something bothered me. The cultural difference between the West and the East appeared as far as the heavens are from the earth yet their people seemed really keen to learn about each other's differences. I so badly wanted them to get to know each other and that's how the idea of a cross-culture music exchange came to mind. After all, music is the universal language.

As I proposed the idea to Penn about the prospects of a cross-culture music exchange, the orchestra also learned about an Opera singer named Sun Ping and thought about collaboration between the Penn Symphony Orchestra and Chinese musicians. I imagined what it would be like to combine Chinese instruments and singers accompanied by a Western symphony, allegedly an unprecedented endeavour by a US university. The University was also excited about it, so we got to work. This involved long rehearsals stretching into late hours of the night in collaboration with Singer Sun Ping and instrumentalist for jinghu and pipa. It was tasking because this was new territory for us. There were language barriers as the Chinese musicians didn't know English just as our conductor didn't know Chinese. We had to

open our minds to accept new ideas, but finally, pieces started to fall into place. However, the entire project was going to be expensive. How were we going to fund this trip to China? I decided to graduate a semester early just to see this play out. I treated this like I was trying to raise capital to start a business. During this journey, I met entrepreneurs and philanthropists and learned about their life stories and why they wanted to support our cause. We received testimonials from government officials from China and US, including former Secretary of State Dr Henry Kissinger, endorsing this collaborative mission of bridging differences and promoting our common interest through the beautiful music of our respective cultures. In a letter to the Penn Symphony Orchestra in 2001, Dr Kissinger wrote, *“You have already made a valuable contribution to the enjoyment and appreciation of China's great musical tradition by presenting an acclaimed program earlier this spring that integrated classical Western music with that of the Beijing Opera. As a music lover and believer in cross-cultural exchange and understanding as a significant factor in the resolution of tensions among nations, I applaud this important step you have taken.”*

Everything was set and the music team comprising 90 members boarded a plane to China, each of us brimming with fresh expectation. For many of us, it was our first time traveling outside of the US.

We arrived at Tsinghua University in the late afternoon for our first rehearsal and nothing prepared us for the kind of welcome we received. We were treated like celebrities. First, we had Sun Ping, and she was sort of a big deal in the Chinese Opera circle. The fact she partnered with us was an endorsement. It was our first time rehearsing with Zhao Yihua and Li Yiping, who played the jinghu and the pipa, traditional Chinese instruments. Sun Ping, Dr. Averbach, and our orchestra had rehearsed together many times at Penn, but Mr Zhao and Mr Li were new to blending their music with ours.

The day had come for our most important concert at the renowned Poly Theatre in Beijing. Sun Ping had personally invited dignitaries and politicians to witness our experiment of merging a symphony orchestra with Beijing Opera. And before my very eyes, I saw a little idea become something so big, that the top dogs in politics

swarmed the most famous music theatre in Beijing just to listen to our performance.

The audience loved the music. The first half of the performance introduced them to the sound of a Western symphony orchestra. The real surprise came in the second half with our Beijing opera. When we played the first aria, hearing their traditional instruments and style of singing supported by the full orchestra sound, they cheered and shouted with joy.

We also performed as part of the Watermelon Festival, an important celebration we hadn't fully grasped until then. A police escort guided us through Beijing's streets, with vehicles and pedestrians clearing the way for our buses. It was both awe-inspiring and intimidating to have police escort us in the capital of the most populous country.

No cultural exchange is complete without visits to historical sites. We visited the Great Wall, Ming Tombs and Forbidden City, a clear symbol of their imperial might. Its grand design and provisions for the emperor left us astounded. Thereafter the Penn Symphony Orchestra performed in Shanghai and Hong Kong to complete its tour of

China. At the Hong Kong concert held at Chinese University, I was the emcee. It was special for many reasons. Firstly, I was back in my birthplace where my family and relatives were present. Many hadn't seen me since I was a little kid and have not heard me speak English, not to mention doing so publicly. Secondly, the President of Penn Dr. Rodin was in town and attended the concert. Jokingly after the concert, she suggested maybe I should work at Penn's development office after graduation.

As we approached San Francisco, a subtle sigh of relief swept through us. We had made it back; triumphant in our successful tour. There was tremendous publicity about our performances in Chinese media. From my entire experience, I learned an important lesson — you must be willing to build on little ideas. That is how great things are birthed even though there may be no monetary rewards. To this day, this is one of my proudest achievements because it has really touched the lives of many living across the ocean. I am deeply thankful for all the sponsors and the University for supporting this cause.

My Last days at Penn

Every good thing has to come to an end they say, and this was also true about my time in college just as I was steadily forming a vision of what life would look like after graduation. From getting admitted into what was arguably the best undergraduate business dual degree program in the world to playing in the Orchestra and making lifelong friends, my time at Penn was unforgettable. But just as with every good finale, you'll often find some level of uncertainty — uncertainty about what the next stage of life holds.

Every day, as I poured over my textbooks and attended lectures on financial markets, I couldn't help but feel a pull towards the real world of finance — a world where the concepts I was studying weren't just theoretical, but tangible, where every decision had real consequences and every dollar mattered. But as the pressure to launch into the world of finance intensified, so did my determination to excel in my studies and social life. I poured over my notes late into the night, then went out to party like there was no tomorrow, determined to squeeze every last drop

of knowledge and will power out of my college experience.

A part of me greatly anticipated launching out into the world of finance but a sense of restlessness stirred within me. The endless cycle of classes, exams, and part-time work felt like a treadmill I couldn't escape. Don't get me wrong, I loved the hustle and bustle of student life, but I would soon be entering the real world now — a world with a different type of hustle. In this new world, different sets of rules apply. In college, everything seemed like a puzzle waiting to be solved. Classes had clear goals, and success meant mastering the material, acing exams, and turning in assignments on time. The path was laid out, and if you followed it diligently, the outcome was generally predictable.

But stepping into the real world was like being thrown into a maze without a map. There were no syllabi or professors to guide me. Instead, I faced ambiguous challenges, unpredictable situations, and relentless competition. Success here demanded more than just knowledge; it required adaptability, resilience, and a willingness to navigate uncertainty.

In college, grades measured my understanding of concepts, but in the real world, results mattered most.

There were no curves or extra credit opportunities — only outcomes that either propelled me forward or held me back. This is where I learned to keep calm and not just hope for the best but to also prepare for the best. Something in me kept telling me to savour these final moments of student life and let the process play out organically.

It was a lesson I learned the hard way, through countless sleepless nights and moments of self-doubt. I realized that rushing into the real world without proper preparation would be like diving headfirst into a pool without knowing how to swim. Sure, I might make a splash, but without the skills and knowledge to navigate the waters, I'd soon find myself sinking.

So, I made a conscious effort to slow down, to breathe, and to enjoy the present moment. I reminded myself that life wasn't just about reaching the next milestone or checking off the next item on my to-do list — it was about the journey, the experiences, and the lessons learned

along the way. Along the way, I remind myself that I could have died at the age of 16. Yet I have been given another chance to live.

As I watched the seasons change outside my dorm room window, I felt a sense of peace wash over me. I realized that there was no need to rush, no need to force myself to fit into a mould that wasn't meant for me. The real world would still be there waiting for me when I was ready, and until then, I would continue to embrace each day with open arms, knowing that the best has yet to come.

CHAPTER FOUR

Embracing Opportunities

In high school, I was like a sponge, soaking up as much knowledge as possible. I took as many classes as I could physically handle, not just because I loved learning, but also because tuition was essentially free regardless of how many courses I took. It was a chance to expand my horizons, and I wasn't about to let it slip by. College was no different. I approached my studies with a sense of duty. Being a student meant striving for excellence, not settling for mediocrity. My parents instilled in me the value of hard work and the importance of seizing every opportunity.

Opportunities are like open doors inviting us to explore new paths, take risks, and pursue our dreams. Most people miss them because they don't come in the form people expect. Opportunities are often disguised as challenges or setbacks, but they always hold the potential for growth and advancement. In Chinese, the word 危机 means "Danger opportunity." Whenever there is danger, there is opportunity. Opportunities can manifest as job offers, chances

to learn new skills, collaborations with others, or even unexpected encounters that spark inspiration. They often require initiative, readiness to seize the moment, and a willingness to step outside our comfort zones.

Embracing opportunities opens doors to personal and professional development, allowing us to expand our horizons, discover our strengths, and fulfil our aspirations. Whether big or small, each opportunity presents a chance to shape our lives, forge meaningful connections, and create a brighter future.

In the early 2000s, the finance industry in New York was like being in a fast-changing world where everything could affect what happened next. As someone trying to figure out how to invest wisely, I saw a lot of big changes happening around me. It all began after the excitement of the dot-com boom in the late 1990s and things started to get shaky. Many tech companies that had seemed unstoppable suddenly ran into trouble, and people who had invested in them lost money. The excitement of the internet era faded, leaving behind a lesson about greed and fear.

Then, September 11, 2001, changed everything. The terrorist attacks shocked New York and made the financial markets tremble. But despite the fear and grief, New York refused to give up, showing resilience in the face of tragedy. I actually lived a few blocks from Ground Zero, and two weeks before the attacks, I visited *Top of the World*, the 107th floor observation deck in the South Tower for the first and last time. I remember very clearly going to work on September 11 and witnessing the pandemonium. I saw vividly the two gaping holes in the Twin Towers from my office and the eventual collapse of the buildings and could not return home for two weeks. And that was only the first month into my career.

During this time, new ways of investing, like hedge funds and private equity, became popular. They promised to make more money and mitigate risk, which caught the attention of investors looking for safer options.

At the same time, the government passed new rules, like the Sarbanes-Oxley Act, to make sure companies were honest about their finances. It was a way to rebuild trust in the financial world after scandals.

Big companies also started joining forces through mergers and acquisitions, changing the landscape of who was in charge and how things worked.

Looking back, the early 2000s were a time of big changes and opportunities in investing and I was just about to step into my first big career boost.

I landed a job in New York, the city that never sleeps. It was a pivotal moment for me. I joined Credit Suisse First Boston (“Credit Suisse”) after its recent merger with Donaldson, Lufkin & Jenrette. The allure of working alongside the best and brightest was irresistible. Once again, I found myself among the very best!

Despite offers received from other prestigious banks, like Goldman Sachs and Morgan Stanley — Credit Suisse was a no brainer because there was very little chance for me to join the mergers & acquisitions group at Goldman Sachs and Morgan Stanley since those were reserved for returning interns, and I didn’t intern at either of these two firms.

For me, it was clear I wanted to start my career in mergers & acquisitions because I thought that would be the clearest path to getting to my next

milestone – private equity. As you recall, my father always reminded me about having a five-year plan, and here I was planning ahead. Frankly, I had no clue what private equity was at the time, but I really enjoyed the book “Barbarians at the Gate” about KKR’s acquisition of RJR Nabisco that I read in my finance class. And in all seriousness, when I watched “Pretty Woman,” I wanted to be Edward Lewis played by Richard Gere. It’s not about the money or women, but I was intrigued by what it would be like to be vicious and ruthless (later I learned that most people in private equity are not like the movie character) because that’s something I inherently am not. Sounds corny, but those were the only two reasons to inspire a 22-year-old. And if it takes starting out in a certain group at a bank to get there, then that’s what it has to be.

At Credit Suisse, all the groups were up for grabs, so I took the leap of faith to see if I could get the group I coveted. I had the privilege to join the Technology Mergers & Acquisitions group at Credit Suisse because it was second to none on Wall Street at the time led by legends in this field. To add icing to the cake, the New York group was led by a Chinese Singaporean. The truth is it is

very rare for an East Asian to be so highly successful in this field. This was the group where I could learn from exceptional people who are the outliers in what they did.

For me, being among the best wasn't about flaunting status; it was about learning from those who excelled in their craft. It was about modelling after them. I craved mentorship, knowing that greatness is earned through dedication and hard work. One question someone I looked up to told me to ask early on in any job interview is “How is my performance measured?” In this case, my boss's response was “In M&A, rule number one - Make sure the numbers are correct. Rule number two – follow rule number one.” Sounds familiar? That's when I learned the importance of being super detail oriented.

Fierce Competition

Thinking back to when I started at Credit Suisse, it feels like stepping into a whole new world full of ups and downs. Fresh out of college, I entered the busy offices of one of Wall Street's biggest players, feeling excited but also apprehensive. The juniors used to call our office building Eleven Madison Avenue the

“Mausoleum” because it resembled one — once you enter it, you never leave it because you end up sleeping there.

At Credit Suisse, competition was fierce, much like my days studying finance at the University of Pennsylvania and in the Huntsman program. Back then, I was surrounded by ambitious peers striving to excel in the world of finance.

In the bustling offices of Credit Suisse, it felt like being in a beehive, with everyone buzzing with activity. Traders, analysts, and professionals worked tirelessly, knowing that every decision could impact someone's fortune. It was a world driven by numbers and strategies, where success was measured by actual dollars. And we are talking about millions and millions of dollars.

Throughout my journey at Credit Suisse and studying finance, I learned valuable lessons about thriving in competition. Competition, I discovered, can take both healthy and unhealthy forms, each with its own set of consequences and implications.

Here at Credit Suisse, the competition was palpable. The drive to outperform peers and secure coveted deals fueled a culture of intense

rivalry. Some individuals embraced competition in unhealthy ways, resorting to cutthroat tactics to gain an edge. This approach, while seemingly effective in the short term, often led to strained relationships, compromised integrity, and ultimately, diminished trust within the workplace.

On the other hand, healthy competition thrives on principles of fairness, collaboration, and mutual respect. Individuals engaged in healthy competition sought to push boundaries, innovate, and excel while upholding ethical standards and integrity. They viewed competition not as a zero-sum game but as an opportunity for growth, learning, and personal development.

I came to understand that competing healthily fosters a positive work environment where individuals support and inspire each other to reach their full potential. A win-win for all. Collaboration replaces cutthroat tactics, and success is celebrated collectively rather than individually. Healthy competition begets innovation, creativity, and resilience. Like, I knew I could be the best at anything I set my mind on. This is the driving force behind dynamic organisations and economies.

At the end of the day not only the individual is rewarded but the overall organisation benefits from it. By embracing healthy competition, we can unlock our full potential, foster meaningful connections, and create a more inclusive and collaborative work environment where everyone has the opportunity to thrive.

Above all that, I started to learn what politics in the workplace meant and the importance of kissing up to your superior. While dedication is an essential ingredient to success, it doesn't guarantee it. Ultimately, the winner of this competition is not determined by a formula, but by emotional human beings. It is the cruel reality of life, and I knew I would not excel in this game because I hated politics and kissing up to people. This is an epiphany that would shape my decisions in the years to come.

Cruelty of the Real World: Revealed

Entering the workforce in the summer of 2001 was not ideal due to 9/11 attacks and the bursting of the tech bubble. There were already layoffs happening around the country, but at Credit Suisse, it was even worse due to the acquisition of DLJ. Even when I was undergoing

my analyst training program that summer, the firm made it clear that it had over-hired from the previous summer. Those who didn't excel in training would have to be cut. Job offers were deferred. During my first six months on the job, there were already layoffs. Bankers get called in to the boss's office, walked out to their desks and packed their bags as they were escorted out of the premise immediately without access to their blackberries and computers. The only conversations I had with those departing was "Cya. Let's catch up outside the office." There was tension everywhere and the mood on the floor was somber. The only saving grace was I was so junior and cheap that they needed bodies to do the grunt work.

In times like this, senior bankers that remained were aggressively pitching for business to justify their existence. Another saving grace for me as a junior analyst was, I was not measured by revenue generated but by number of pitch books prepared and whether the numbers were accurate. Despite the industry being in the doldrums, I was fortunate to have closed some interesting deals. I achieved a record of working 140 hours (about 6 days) a week inside the Mausoleum.

CHAPTER FIVE

Learning from the Best

I have always believed that a person who walks with the wise will be wise and one who walks with a company of fools will become foolish. Most times, people underestimate the power of peer pressure. The truth is a very small percentage of our actions emanates from our active consciousness. As humans, we subconsciously mirror the world around us. This is why I made up my mind to always surround myself with outstanding people. Success is not overrated. I have seen people downplay the successes of others and attribute them purely to luck in an attempt to water down the process. In reality, success is a repeatable process and a choice that anyone can make. But the truth is, this is one of life's hardest decisions because if it was so easy, everyone would be successful. I could have grown up to become a hater and blame the world for the disadvantages in my life, but I wasn't

going to do that because it achieves nothing. Absolutely nothing!

Success flows in patterns and as such can be learned. This was a big turning point in my life when I discovered that successful folks didn't have two heads. What made them so distinguished were the secrets they knew and practiced. And they had these secrets because they learned it from their mentors. People are the best at what they do for a reason and if they can sustain that, then it is not luck. There is a repeatable process, and there is a reason why they are so good at what they do. For me, this was the thing that fuelled my drive for excellence. I wanted to be with the best so I can enhance my chances of becoming the best that I can be. If I got to learn about those secrets, I can be successful. I began by outlining every area of my life where I wanted to scale up or do better and find a mentor who has achieved the very thing I was striving for.

I finished my career at Credit Suisse in the Financial Sponsors Group, a group that specialized in advising private equity firms in doing leveraged buyouts. This is what DLJ was known for, and I wanted to join the action.

Off to Asia

By 2004, I had left Credit Suisse and set off for Hong Kong. Hong Kong is mostly known for its rich culture, ancestry, festivals, arts and traditions but beyond that, Hong Kong is also recognized as a major global financial centre, housing the Hong Kong Stock Exchange, serving as a hub for international business and finance and gateway to the rise of China. It would seem that I was married to good fortune because I ended up working in a top US private equity firm.

The financial climate in Hong Kong back then was different. In the early 2000s, even though the financial sector was booming, there were only a handful of private equity firms that were truly notable. One could count them with one hand like CVC, Warburg Pincus, Carlyle and Newbridge (prior to TPG) and they didn't hire a lot of people back in the day. In aggregate, they would probably recruit 10 people into what we called 'the 1st year Associate class.' Thus, getting in was a big deal for me. It reminded me of how I felt when I got into the Huntsman Program. I was very lucky to be one of the few people who would move to Hong Kong as an expat to join the

incoming associate class at one of these elite firms.

I spent three years there, again with incredible mentors, and that is why I have a whole chapter in this Memoir dedicated to them. These were all rainmakers of the Asian private equity industry. The deals they did and the statements they made were recorded in the history books. I was very fortunate to have worked for them and learned from them as I spent a year and a half in Australia and the rest in China.

What is Work?

This is also something people have taught me early on, that is, what is work? Why do you like going to work? Some people will say it's the money, it's the excitement, and it's the fame. For me I always felt, even when I was young my parents would teach me that work is a place to learn and there is no better place to learn than working because you are getting paid at the same time.

I saw work as being more than just a job — it was a journey of self-discovery and personal growth, even amidst its challenges. Working 100 hours a week may sound daunting to some, but for me, it

was oddly acceptable. In my late twenties, I embraced the intensity of my work hours, seeing them as opportunities rather than setbacks. There is the famous saying that “If you do what you love, you’ll never work a day in your life.” I think that is quite true.

I viewed my job as a chance to learn from the best, to immerse myself in a platform that was established and ripe with knowledge. The deals I worked on had the potential to make headlines. Every challenge was a chance to expand my horizons and develop new skills. Even when I found myself in remote provinces of China, far from the comforts of modernity, I saw each journey as an adventure.

Travelling to undeveloped places with basic amenities might deter some, but for me, it was an opportunity to explore the unknown and to experience cultures untouched by modernization. Despite the less-than-ideal living conditions, I approached each experience with optimism and gratitude.

Many would have hesitated to accept such assignments, citing discomfort or inconvenience. But I thought to myself, I must get in on this

saying! Someone was footing the bill for my accommodations, travel expenses, meeting interesting people and honing my language — why would I turn down such an opportunity for growth and exploration?

This mindset, this willingness to embrace discomfort and uncertainty, set me apart from others. While some may shy away from the unknown, I leaned into it, eager to discover what lay beyond the familiar.

When I look back at it all, I realize that the pain and discomfort I encountered along the way were not obstacles but stepping stones on my journey. They taught me resilience, adaptability, and the value of seizing every opportunity, no matter how unconventional it may seem.

So, to those who see pain as a barrier, I say this: Embrace it. Embrace the discomfort, the uncertainty, and the challenges, for within them lies the potential for growth, fulfilment, and discovery. It is through embracing the pain that we truly learn what we are capable of and unlock the boundless possibilities that await us. It is from falling do we learn to get back up.

The Art of Negotiation

Negotiation truly is an art form like playing the violin, painting a portrait or even martial arts. I consider it a survival skill and a proof of competence. I started learning the art of negotiations early on, even as far back as my school days. During my high school days, I was busy trading comic books. I would negotiate with buyers, introduce competing bids and host auctions. I realized that negotiation wasn't just about the exchange of goods but about the exchange of ideas and perspectives. The moment I got to understand what the other party wanted; it became easier to close deals at the most attractive terms for me as possible.

One key lesson I also discovered is the importance of knowing your bottom line before entering into negotiations. It's essential to establish non-negotiable terms and be prepared to walk away if those terms are not met. Negotiation isn't about bending over and letting the other party have their way — it's about knowing when to stand firm and assert your boundaries. Without a clear understanding of

your limits and objectives, negotiations can devolve into a game of take it or leave it, where neither party truly benefits.

People often overlook the enforcement part of contract. That's when the importance between commercial and legal consideration comes in. An unenforceable contract is a worthless piece of paper. Enforcing a contract is like making sure everyone delivers on the promises they've made. It is as simple as saying if a staff resigns, he is to serve a defined notice period. But what happens if he doesn't and just decides not to show up tomorrow? That's where the terms of the contract come into play to state the staff needs to pay in-lieu of notice.

When negotiating solid terms, it's not just about what's written on paper; it's about making sure there are realistic consequences if someone doesn't hold up their end of the bargain. That's why it's important to include clauses like, "If either walk away from the deal, then there is a break fee of X dollars." This puts some teeth into the contract and ensures that there is real accountability. But parties also need to know whether the breaching party can actually afford to

pay such a penalty. Otherwise, even though the penalty is defined, it may not amount to anything.

Another crucial aspect is setting clear timeframes for actions and responsibilities. Instead of leaving things open-ended, it's better to specify deadlines and consequences for missing them. For instance, rather than merely stating “a penalty is to be paid,” it is better to state “a penalty is to be paid within five business days after written notice is served” to add clarity and urgency to the agreement.

When it comes to negotiation and legal contracts, the devil truly is in the details. Every word, clause, sentence, and paragraph matters. That's why it's essential to pay close attention to the fine print and ensure that there are no loopholes that could be exploited later on. In the world of contracts, it's not about being overly cautious — it's about being thorough and ensuring that everyone plays by the rules and that every downside scenario is covered. Having a capable lawyer is of course crucial.

I also learned that negotiation styles can vary significantly between different cultures. In China, for example, negotiations may be approached

with more subtlety and restraint, particularly in friendly or informal settings. Certain terms may be left unspoken out of cultural sensitivity, but it's important to remain vigilant and assume that the other party may not have your best interests at heart.

Ultimately, the essence of negotiation lies in safeguarding your own interests while finding mutually beneficial solutions. By knowing your bottom line, understanding the ultimate price, and being mindful of cultural differences, you can navigate negotiations with confidence and integrity, ensuring that your interests are protected in every deal.

Breaking Limits

During my private equity days, I embarked on an incredible journey that reshaped my career and taught me valuable lessons about success.

My company was a place where dreams became reality and challenges turned into opportunities. I was given important responsibilities, like transforming companies and making impactful financial decisions. Working with experienced colleagues, I learned how to navigate the complex

world of deal making and make strategic moves that mattered.

One of the highlights was meeting with top government officials and business builders — a moment that showed me the power of leadership and negotiation. These meetings were a big deal and taught me a lot about diplomacy and working with influential people. It was incredible that at 27 years old, I was given the opportunity to negotiate financing deals in Chinese with the municipal head of a major SOE bank. I would literally walk into a board room alone and sitting across from me was a team of 5 people, some of whom were almost my parents' age. I was given the opportunity to be a semi-C-suite role in a portfolio company until we could find someone permanent. Sitting across from these esteemed individuals, I often felt the weight of the responsibility placed upon my shoulders. There were moments when doubts crept in when I questioned whether I was truly capable of handling such immense tasks at such a young age. Yet, it was during these moments of doubt that I learned one of life's most valuable lessons: courage is not the absence of fear, but the willingness to act despite it. This was an iconic

experience that gave me the confidence to become an entrepreneur and business builder.

I discovered that it's okay to feel afraid and to acknowledge the doubts and insecurities that accompany stepping into the unknown. What truly matters is finding the inner strength and resilience to confront those fears head-on, and to embrace the challenges before us with composure and determination.

Beyond the fancy meetings and newsworthy deals, what mattered most was our commitment to making a difference. We worked hard to transform companies and make positive changes in various industries.

I discovered that success is more than just reaching a goal — it's about daring to dream, working hard, and never giving up. It's about pushing past limits and making a positive impact on the world around us.

Looking back on my time in private equity, I'm grateful for the lessons learned and the friendships made. It was a journey of growth, resilience, and the belief that anything is possible if you're willing to work for it.

It's about breaking limits and reaching for the stars, knowing that with dedication and determination, anything is possible. For that I am deeply grateful.

And one more thing, my bosses were not ruthless like Edward Lewis. They were strict for my own good, but kind and supportive like a parent to a child.

CHAPTER SIX

From Private Equity to Hedge Funds

In life, and especially in our careers, change is like the wind that pushes a sailboat forward — it propels us toward new horizons and opportunities. And as I reflect on my journey from private equity to hedge funds, I've come to realize the profound importance of embracing change in our professional lives. Change isn't always easy. It can be scary, uncertain, and filled with unknowns. But it's also the catalyst for growth, innovation, and transformation. Without change, we risk stagnation, becoming stuck in the comfortable familiarity of the status quo. It gets boring.

Embracing change means stepping out of our comfort zones, venturing into uncharted territory, and daring to challenge ourselves in new ways. It's about being open to new experiences, perspectives, and possibilities — to the winds of change that carry us toward new thresholds and heights in our careers. Change forces us to adapt, learn, and evolve — to become better versions of ourselves. It pushes us to confront our fears, to

test our limits, and to discover the depths of our resilience and determination.

As I made the leap from private equity to hedge funds, I confronted the uncertainties and challenges that change brings. Yet, in that journey, I found not just obstacles, but opportunities — not just endings, but new beginnings.

In the early parts of 2007, I faced a big decision in my finance career. I was just about 27 years old approaching 28. At this time, I was still working in Hong Kong, diving deep into the world of money and investments. I started out in private equity, where we worked on landmark deals. It was exciting, and I learned a lot interacting with business builders about how businesses work and how to structure deals.

But then, I had an awakening. I knew early on that politics or dealing with people wasn't my forte; therefore, I needed a career where performance was measured strictly by numbers. Either you make it, or you don't. No BS. That's when I decided to step into the world of hedge funds. Now I was looking at charts and graphs and doing some hard-core financial analysis. For those of us

who are not financially savvy, let me drop some insights on what hedge funds are all about. Hedge funds are like turbocharged investments — they move fast, take calculated risks. It's a place where people use all sorts of strategies to try and make money, from longing and shorting stocks, technical analysis, understanding macroeconomics and foreign currency. Being part of a hedge fund meant having to constantly make decisions in a short period of time. You know in a short period of time whether you are right or wrong, and there is no place to hide. But I was up for the challenge. In hindsight, I realize being decisive and embracing the outcome of those decisions is a rare skill. It is difficult to train unless one is constantly put into situations that require one to do so.

When I made the switch to a top-tier hedge fund in Asia, I entered a realm where excellence was the standard, not just a goal. Working alongside the best in the industry, I found myself surrounded by large investors known for their rigorous standards, sharp intellects, and unwavering work ethics.

In movies like "Wall Street" and its sequel, "Wall Street: Money Never Sleeps," hedge fund

managers are often depicted as ruthless, greedy individuals who will stop at nothing to make money. Characters like Gordon Gekko represent this stereotype — slick, morally bankrupt, and driven solely by profit.

Similarly, in "The Wolf of Wall Street," the protagonist, Jordan Belfort, runs a brokerage firm that engages in fraudulent activities to make huge profits. While not specifically about hedge funds, the movie portrays the finance industry as a whole in a negative light, highlighting the excesses and unethical behavior that can occur.

These portrayals, while entertaining, don't always reflect the reality of hedge funds. In reality, hedge funds encompass a wide range of strategies, approaches, personalities, and not all managers are like the characters we see on screen. In my experience, working in hedge funds has been about diligent research, strategic decision-making, responsible risk management, and substantive debate.

While Hollywood may sensationalize certain aspects of the finance industry, it's important to remember that reality is often more nuanced. Not all hedge fund managers are Gordon Gekkos or

Jordan Belforts. Many are dedicated professionals who strive to create real value for their investors while upholding the highest standards of ethics and integrity.

So back to my narrative, I found myself in a dynamic environment, and my growth was boundless. Every interaction, every ticker, became an opportunity to learn and evolve. From dissecting intricate investment strategies and financial statements to navigating volatile market conditions, I embraced each challenge with determination and curiosity.

The bosses I worked with demanded nothing short of excellence, pushing me further than ever before. Their high expectations catalysed my development, driving me to exceed my limitations and strive for mastery in my craft. Another thing I will always be grateful for is the trust they bestowed upon me. It was like they saw something in me that I didn't even see in myself.

With each passing day, I grew more confident in my abilities and more comfortable in my role as an investment professional. I learned to trust my instincts, to rely on my knowledge and expertise,

and to approach every decision with a clear mind and a steady hand.

As I navigated the complexities of the financial world, I realized that courage isn't about being fearless — it's about having the courage to acknowledge our fears and move forward despite them. It's about embracing uncertainty and admitting to mistakes with grace and resilience.

In this season of growth, I honed my analytical skills and decision-making skills and cultivated a mindset of resilience and adaptability. I learned to thrive under pressure, embrace uncertainty, and approach each endeavor with unwavering commitment and integrity. I learned that one day you could be down twenty million dollars, but up thirty million the next. At the end, I go through massive mood swings looking at numbers on the screen, but my lifestyle and values remain the same. More importantly, I learned to say “Buy”, “Sell” or “Do Nothing” with conviction. I learned what it meant to take full ownership of my work rather than being merely an adviser or agent. I fully understood the psychological difference between being on the buy side vs. the sell side.

But perhaps, more than anything, it was the ethos of the firm — the relentless pursuit of excellence, the unwavering dedication to performance — that left an indelible mark on my journey. My superiors were ultra-intelligent and supportive of my well-being. We were like a little family. It was a reminder that greatness is not achieved in isolation but through collaboration, debate, mentorship, and a shared commitment to continuous improvement.

A Bumpy 2007

In 2007, the financial world was going through a wild ride. Markets were booming despite cracks appearing in the US economy. Hedge funds were right in the middle of it all, trying to make sense of the chaos and find opportunities to make money. This was the climax of the movie “The Big Short.”

Being part of a hedge fund was like being in the eye of a storm. Every day brought new challenges and risks, but also new chances to make smart moves and turn a profit. In the hedge fund world, people use all kinds of tricks to try and make money. Some focus on buying and selling stocks quickly to catch short-term gains. Others dive

into complex financial instruments like options and futures, trying to predict which way the market will move.

But it's not all about making money. Hedge funds also have a big responsibility. I have always considered myself to be somewhat of a conservative. Now I'm not saying everyone must be like me. There are many ways to invest so whatever works for you is fine. Being a conservative investor means I'm cautious with my money. I prefer to invest in less risky things, even if it means I might not make as much profit. I like to choose stable investments, rather than taking chances on high-risk opportunities. What that means is anything that has a risk reward less favorable than 35% upside and 10% downside per annum is generally unappealing. Next is sizing of those bets. It's all about being careful and thinking long-term, making sure my money is safe and grows steadily over time.

Most hedge funds manage money for wealthy investors, pension funds, endowments and large institutions. That means they have to be careful with their decisions and make sure they're doing right by their clients. That's why we need to do our thorough research, understand the market, and

stick to the philosophy and style we promised our investors.

Being part of a hedge fund was challenging, exciting, and sometimes nerve-wracking. But it was also a chance to learn and grow, to test my skills against the fast-moving currents of the market. One moment you lose tons of money and get humiliated in front of your colleagues and in the next, you're receiving a seven-figure check, a pat on the back while your superiors brand you as a financial wiz. The emotional roller coaster is not everyone's cup of tea.

Stay True to Yourself

Ever stopped to ask yourself the question, "Who am I? What do I value most in life?" I say this because it would be impossible to talk about staying true to yourself if you don't even know who you are. It's a common belief that money changes people but I think a more suitable statement is that money amplifies the character that already exists in the hearts of human. With money, doors of opportunities open, and you now have more options. This is when you'll get to find out who you really are.

In the high-stakes world of finance, where fortunes are made and lost in the blink of an eye, it's easy to succumb to the allure of wealth. As someone who has navigated the tumultuous waters of the hedge fund industry, I've witnessed firsthand the transformative power of money. Yet, amid the chaos of my time in New York and Asia, I've held firm to a simple belief: money shouldn't change who you truly are.

When you've been around the block long enough, you get to see things you least expected. Throughout my career, I've seen colleagues and peers morph into caricatures of themselves as their bank accounts swelled. Expensive suits, flashy cars, and ostentatious displays of wealth became the norm. But for me, the trappings of affluence held little appeal. I generally still wear the same clothes and shoes I wore in my college days, not out of frugality, but out of principle.

To me, money is nothing more than a number on a screen, a tool to be used wisely but never worshipped. It's akin to the pieces in a game of Monopoly — valuable only within the confines of the board. What truly matters are the values and principles that guide us, irrespective of our financial standing. There are only a few things we

need in life, and those cannot be bought with money – freedom, purpose, love, family, friendship, dignity and health. Knowing that, most of us still belabour ourselves and run in this incessant rat race due to greed and wants.

In a world where materialism reigns supreme, staying true to oneself amidst the allure of wealth is a testament to character. For me, humility, integrity, and authenticity will always outweigh the fleeting allure of riches. Money may buy comfort and convenience, but it should never purchase the essence of who we are. And so, I remain steadfast in my conviction that no matter the balance in my bank account, I am, and will always be, the same person at heart. Once again, when I look back, I realize that a lot of my values came from my parents. They came from humble beginnings, so I am just a farm boy who got lucky.

From Hero to Zero

The year 2008 marked a turning point in the financial landscape, a seismic shift that reverberated through the halls of institutions and the lives of individuals alike. The world grappled with the aftermath of the financial crisis and uncertainty hung heavy in the air like a dense fog

obscuring the path forward. Bear Stearns had collapsed earlier in the year. The cataclysmic demise of Lehman shook the globe, and we felt the end of the world was near.

March 2009 dawned with an ominous sense of foreboding. The New York Stock Exchange, a barometer of economic vitality, plunged to unprecedented depths, plunging investor confidence to new lows. It was a day etched in memory. You could smell the apprehension in the air.

Stepping into the office that fateful morning, I braced myself for the inevitable. Rumours swirled, whispers of impending doom that permeated the once bustling trading floor. And then, like a thunderclap shattering the silence, the announcement came: my employer, a bastion of financial prowess, would cease operations, returning capital to investors.

In an instant, the ground beneath my feet crumbled, leaving me adrift in a sea of uncertainty. I was now faced with the prospects of unemployment like a man looking down the barrel gun. From a position of promise and potential, I found myself thrust into the ranks of

the jobless, a casualty of circumstances beyond my control. Only a year ago this time I raked in 7 digits for the first time only to be unemployed shortly thereafter.

In the blink of an eye, the trajectory of my life had been irrevocably altered, reduced to a series of dashed hopes and shattered dreams. Yet, amid the wreckage of shattered expectations, a flicker of resilience ignited within me, a beacon of hope amidst the encroaching darkness.

For in the face of adversity, true character is revealed. And though I may have been stripped of title, prestige and a fat paycheck, I remained unbroken. I knew I was still highly valuable even without a job.

And so, with my head held high and determination ablaze, I embarked on a journey of self-discovery, charting a course towards new horizons and uncharted shores. For in the ebb and flow of fortune, I learned that true wealth lies not in the coffers of banks, but in the depths of the human spirit and core values.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Back to the Saddle

The recession of 2008 was a time of unprecedented struggle in the United States. Back then, the economy was in a dire state which resulted in many people having lost their jobs, their savings, and their homes. It was indeed a time of great hardship and one which did leave a lasting mark on me and so many others who witnessed it.

Firstly, the economy was in shambles plus the job market was in complete disarray. Many companies downsized and tried to cut costs wherever they could. The unemployment rate in the US soared to 10% as it was one of those times in America when everyone was actually affected. A good instance was that every job opening had hundreds of qualified applicants and that made it nearly impossible to stand out.

I for one saw firsthand the impact that the recession was having on individuals and families to the point where the sense of despair and uncertainty it brought became so palpable. Even though in Asia we were more insulated than the West, it was hard not to feel affected by it.

The year 2009 promised to be better because we survived Lehman, but I was one of the many who lost my job.

Career Detour

Being laid-off was one of the hardest experiences I had to go through. I remember walking into the building and hearing the boss pronounce that the fund was shutting down. It had happened so fast that I did not have enough time to react. It took a while for the news to register in my head, but by then, I had no idea how to react. As I walked out of the building for the last time, I felt a sense of dread that was difficult to shake off.

In the weeks that followed, I was filled with anxiety. I felt lost and unsure about what to do

next. But I knew that I couldn't just sit around feeling sorry for myself. I had to find a new source of income though I was not in a hurry. What was ahead of me would be daunting, so I decided to take my time to explore all the available options. However, being very ultra-competitive, deep inside I was anxious to find something quickly because I didn't want to lag behind my peers who still had jobs and glamorous name cards. I had set out three options; either could have worked in my case.

Firstly, I could look for another job. That was the first thing that came to mind. Hunting for jobs at a time like this was not going to be easy for me. For a start, the job market favored employers. The pay for available positions was far lower than what I had been making. Besides many businesses weren't even hiring. And even if I did find a job, it may be a step down especially since I was unemployed. However, it would only take my persistence to keep searching. And one day, I would likely find a golden opportunity in the hedge fund that would help me get back on my feet again.

On second thought, there was the option of taking a break. Losing my job did take a toll on me, and I thought it would be best to have some time to recover and find my bearings again. Maybe I could get an MBA? I learned in an article that at times like this, it was not a bad idea to give ourselves permission to slow down and care for ourselves, for our mental and physical well-being. Also, this was an avenue to reflect on my goals and priorities to rediscover what truly mattered to me. But on the other hand, I didn't think it was a good idea because of the saying that delay was dangerous. Whatever I wanted to do, I thought it would be best if I started it already.

And finally, I considered starting something on my own. I had always wanted this for me. It started at a very young age when I always admired my father's entrepreneurial spirit. He had started his own business at a time when he had no other options to penetrate the corporate ceiling. Watching him build his business from the ground up left a lasting impression on me,

and I knew that someday, I wanted to start something on my own, too.

My father's journey into the business world was not an easy one, and in my opinion, it was a bit unconventional. He had worked as an employee for many years at a large multi-national company but was never able to advance due to his lack of higher education. Because my father did not have a college degree, his boss had told him outright that he would not be promoted beyond a certain level. If he stayed, he would forever be stuck with a capped salary. But if he abandoned the job to explore other options, there was a high chance he may not get a better or even similar job due to lack of education. And this left my father with a dire choice to make for himself and his family which was to either stay with his dead-end job or take a leap of faith and start his own business. And he chose the latter.

For him, the scenarios were clear, but somewhat binary. One could argue it was a no brainer decision to take the entrepreneurial route or could have been the most difficult decision to

leave the job. He knew that his only path to break the glass ceiling and financial security was by creating something of his own. Plus there were other benefits of being his own boss. It was a bold move, one that required him to sacrifice almost everything he had built up until that point. My grandma pawned her jewelry, and our relatives lent money and sold whatever they could to give my dad his first nest of capital. But he was determined to make it work, and he worked tirelessly to make his business take off. Those were the invaluable lessons I learned from my father, and they guided me until that moment when I had to pick out of all three choices.

Things turned out to be a bit different for me. I had under my belt a rather respectable pedigree. People with my pedigree aren't supposed to be laid-off, right? I'm supposed to succeed, right? What would people think of me if I failed? Will they question whether my pedigree was nothing but a sham? Despite this, the decision before me was clear. Past encounters with failure, including a period of unemployment, had taught me

resilience. Just like the popular proverb that says, “When you hit rock bottom, the only way is up.”

Ultimately, I chose the third option which was to start my own gig. Having witnessed firsthand the risks and rewards of entrepreneurship, I was not afraid to take control of my destiny.

Vision

When the time came for me to start my own business, I knew that the road ahead would be arduous. But I also believed that if my father could do it, so could I. Starting my own business was not just about creating financial security for me, but about pursuing a true purpose.

Also, freedom was always important to me, a value that became the priority as I got older. I valued the freedom to do anything, to work as hard and as long as I wanted to, to spend time on things that are important to me. I knew that starting my own business would be a gamble, but the freedom to work on something that I truly cared about outweighed any potential risks. For

sure, it outweighed the scenario of letting others control my destiny by firing me at any time.

Money was never the driving force behind my decision to start my own business. After all, money never shaped my personality or lifestyle. I didn't buy myself extravagant items like a lot of people may have; I only bought things I needed. What I did with most of the money I ever earned was invest it. What actually mattered most to me was the experience I could get from being my own boss. Even if my business were to fail, I knew that the experiences I would garner would be worth their weight in gold.

But like most people, I overanalyzed. The business hadn't even launched and yet I'm worried about failing. Paranoia crept in. I should only be worried about how to get it started. That's like me worrying more about a car running out of fuel before I even ignited the engine.

Of course, there were still many uncertainties and unknowns that came with starting a business. But I approached them with a sense of

excitement hoping to bring my vision to life. And I can proudly say it was one of the best decisions I ever made.

I remember how glad my father was when I mentioned to him that I plan to start my own business at 30. He straight-up told me that I was a winner for breaking away. I didn't understand what he meant at first, but when I got to think of it, I finally understood what he meant. For generations, we had been farmers, living off the land and working hard to make ends meet hoping customers would purchase our harvest. We had lived at the mercy of the weather and others. None of them were ever as educated as I was. And I happened to be the only person who got the opportunity and qualification to break away and take it.

To my parents, my sister and I were already winners because we went to college. My father would always say "Regardless of what happens, we have already won as a generation." Therefore, I couldn't lose even if the business failed; what mattered was the fact that I had chosen my freedom over everything else.

My father's words stuck with me as I embarked on my journey as an entrepreneur. More than anything, my father's words gave me the courage and the conviction I needed to keep going, even when things got tough.

Vision to Reality

So, I was just a few months shy of my 30th birthday when I realized I had lost my job. After making up my mind, I embarked on the journey of creating a path for myself. But it started with a challenge. Every business needs capital and that was what I lacked to start mine. I thought of many ways to raise capital, and I was reminded of what my father did, which was to pawn his family's jewelry.

I looked at everything I had and realized I didn't have much. But what I had, I was willing to put on the line because as somebody who had already won, there was nothing to lose. Over the years, I have always been scrupulous about my money. I had never been one to spend my hard-earned cash on flashy cars, clothes, or jewelry.

Instead, I had always been focused on investing my money and building something that would last. Every extra dollar I had I put into assets with the potential to appreciate. Now, the time has come to make use of those investments.

I believe that entering the world of entrepreneurship with the mindset of having nothing to lose was a double-edged sword, yet it worked too well because then you would be ready to take risks. But running a business is mostly about taking calculated risks, not just any risk. Using this approach gave me the audacity to embrace challenges that I never would have faced before. Worst case is I get a job in a hedge fund, which is where I was anyway.

Embarking on the entrepreneurial journey often involves stepping out of comfort zones and facing significant challenges. Despite these difficulties, such experiences can be incredibly rewarding. An adventurous mindset and the conviction that there's nothing to lose can drive one to persist through adversity. This confidence and self-investment are crucial in making strides towards one's goals.

I took a decisive step towards a new future. I sold my properties and converted my investments into cash, setting the stage for my entrepreneurial endeavors. I put it all on the line, fully aware of the risks involved. I accepted the uncertainty and potential exposure that came with such a significant leap. I constantly reminded myself that, even if the business did not flourish despite my best efforts, I would not be left with lingering 'what ifs.' The prospect of returning to a traditional employment setting was always there as a safety net, but I was convinced that the knowledge and experience I would gain from this journey would be of great value, regardless of the outcome.

Understanding Opportunity Cost

In life, the idea of opportunity cost teaches us about making sacrifices and being resilient. I learned about it by looking at my dad's journey and my own decisions to start my own hedge fund.

My dad left his stagnant job to start his own business, showing me what opportunity cost means. It's probably a mid-level job he probably could've kept forever because he was overqualified in experience, but the upside was capped due to lack of education. That's leaving a lot of money on the table. Thinking about my own choices, I realized that starting a business for me wasn't as risky as it appeared. Here's why:

I value freedom. I wanted to be in charge of my own time and decisions, even if it meant not having a stable paycheck or working longer hours. Money doesn't define me, so I wasn't afraid of my bank account not growing as fast as others. Even if my business didn't work out, I wouldn't lose the skills and experience I gained from trying. But still, I had to pay the price. And there is no escaping this, especially if you want to do something meaningful. The value of an object is determined by what was sacrificed to obtain it.

As I look back on my journey from leaving a high-paying job to starting my hedge fund, I remember the tough battles I faced and one of

them was not knowing how much money I'd make (or lose).

Imagine leaving a job where you get paid regularly to start something new. It's like walking into a dark room without knowing what's ahead. Suddenly you get punched on the left then the right.

Then there was the disadvantage of not having benefits like health insurance. At my old job, I had top-of-the-line health insurance and other perks like flying business class, staying in five-star hotels and racking up the membership rewards. Service providers looked up to me like a celebrity because of my employer. But when you start your own business, you have to figure that out yourself. I would be a nobody as I would need to kiss up to the same service providers to ask them for favors. These perks I had enjoyed would have to come out of my own pocket.

Starting a business also means working a lot, often more than you did before. I spent many late nights and weekends working on my business. In a start-up, you have to be a Jack of All Trades,

taking on tasks that you didn't know you were capable of doing or even existed. For those who have children, it's like taking on a new role as a parent. For pet owners, it's similar. You can still outsource, but ultimately, it's your baby.

One of the scariest parts of starting a business is that it might not work out. A majority of startups fail, and that is a tough fact an entrepreneur has to accept.

On the flip side, there were the success stories of those who built their hedge funds from scratch. I have always believed in learning from the best, so I undertook to study their processes.

Ray Dalio, the visionary founder of Bridgewater Associates, embarked on his journey in 1975 with nothing but a dream and \$5 million in management from his apartment. Despite facing financial insecurity and skepticism from potential investors, Dalio's unwavering dedication and innovative investment strategies propelled Bridgewater to become a powerhouse in the hedge fund industry.

George Soros, renowned for his bold investment strategies, founded Soros Fund Management in 1969. His early career was marked by setbacks, including losses and criticism from peers. Yet, Soros persevered, eventually earning billions of dollars through his hedge fund, a testament to his resilience and foresight.

Paul Tudor Jones, the founder of Tudor Investment Corporation, overcame challenges on his path to success. Starting as a commodities trader, Jones transitioned to managing his hedge fund. Despite facing market downturns and periods of underperformance, Jones' disciplined approach and adaptability contributed to his eventual triumph as a hedge fund manager.

These stories underscore the sacrifices, long-term commitment and determination required to navigate the complexities of the hedge fund industry. From financial uncertainty to professional challenges, these individuals epitomize the spirit of entrepreneurship and serve as beacons of inspiration for aspiring hedge fund managers embarking on their entrepreneurial journeys.

The final cost of starting a business is that it can be lonely. When you're busy working on your business, you might not have as much time for your friends and family. But even with all these challenges, I kept going because I believed in my dreams. Regardless of the outcome, I own this. Every obstacle taught me something new, and I grew stronger because of them. Looking back, I'm grateful for the journey and everything I learned along the way.

Understanding opportunity cost means realizing that every choice we make comes with a trade-off. It's about giving up something to gain something else. For me, it meant giving up stability for the chance to chase my dream, freedom and purpose. And that's a risk I was willing to take.

Reality

When I had just turned thirty years old, I took on the biggest risk of my life and started my hedge fund. It was a complete one-eighty for someone who was perceived as cautious and risk-averse when it came to financial investments.

But I had a drive to succeed that kept me going even when the odds were against me.

Starting a hedge fund in 2009 was not easy because of the dire state of the global economy. It was the tail end of the financial crisis and therefore, it was extremely tough to raise capital. As mentioned previously, I believed in the phrase 危机 which means “risk opportunity.” Another opportunity arose to enhance the probability of success of my dream, and I took it.

My college classmate was just as eager to start a hedge fund as I was. During our investment career, we were always exchanging ideas. And the great thing was he also just lost his job around the same time as I did! With combined resources, we were able to pull it off and became co-founders. After 50 rejections, we were fortunate enough to have an institutional investor seed us. And when we launched in 2010, Bloomberg and hedge fund magazines wrote about us.

To start a hedge fund, we had to first go through the rigorous process of getting a license and

obtain regulatory approvals. We couldn't splurge on top-tier lawyers, but it helped that we were young, so it was easier for us to do a lot of those things on our own without using an agent. All we had to do was to seek guidance from those who had been through it before and have become well-grounded in the business. It was not just people, but we searched websites, articles, and newspapers, anything we could get our hands on. We were not afraid to call the regulators to answer our questions. Not only did this save us a lot of money, but we learned so much in the process because we rolled up our sleeves and got our hands dirty.

It also gave us so many fulfillments that we built everything from scratch on our own — from raising capital to getting our asset management licenses, building IT infrastructure, constructing and managing a portfolio. While it was thrilling, it was no doubt exhausting and daunting. But each time, I kept reminding myself that this was a once in a lifetime opportunity that could never be wasted. And this pushed me forward despite the sleepless nights.

When I say sleepless nights, I mean it literally. Because I was in Hong Kong I was affected by the time differences between Asia and America. The New York time zone was 12 hours behind that of Hong Kong, so every day I had to sleep at about 2.00 AM observing the US market and then wake up a few hours later to trade the Asian market.

To keep the business running, I had to handle different roles. While I was a portfolio manager, some days I was the Chief Executive Officer. On other days, I could be the compliance officer or the risk officer. Then I was the investor relations manager. You could say I became the Jack of All Trades because it became necessary since our business was just a small startup.

As new business owners, we made a lot of mistakes, thankfully minor ones, but they all served as valuable lessons for achieving my eventual freedom. We were fighting an uphill battle because we didn't have a formal track record of managing money. The whole idea of starting the hedge fund was to solve that – to build a track record that we can own for

ourselves. Perhaps I could've continued working at large firms or banks and waited until my late thirties or early forties to start, but by then there may be other reasons not to start my own business.

There were times when I felt as though I had risked everything for nothing. Had I taken the first choice and got jobs at large institutions, say a large bank or fund, financially I would have been better off. But how does having another zero to my bank account change me or my lifestyle? Nothing really. I believe everything happens for a reason because God put this door in front of me and I chose to walk through it.

Running a startup generally does not pay a lot. For one, my partner and I didn't pay ourselves. We half-jokingly tell people we can't even get approved for a credit card due to lack of income proof.

My journey as a business owner was challenging but also rewarding. Nevertheless, I never regretted deciding to pick the third option

despite not achieving the milestone I had expected. I am grateful for the lessons I have learned and the experiences that have pushed me out of my comfort zone. I realize now that putting everything on the line was the best decision I ever made. It has taught me to bet on myself, to take risks, and to embrace failure.

Although we were far from being Ray Dalio or George Soros, as far as my experience was concerned, it was invaluable. Being my own boss, gaining the respect of people, and most importantly, learning how to manage money on my own terms was truly overwhelming and a very humbling experience. I could see and feel the positive impact that my hard work and dedication had on people. I can always look back on the fact our fund got nominated for Best New Asian Hedge Fund of the year in 2014. My partner and I had the guts to bet a significant portion of our wealth on ourselves, into something we believed in at 30 years old. That is something we will always be proud of. Many intelligent people with pedigree do not have a sliver of courage to do so.

Ultimately, stepping away from our startup and entrusting it to my co-founder was difficult, yet necessary. While some might view this as a setback, I saw it differently. My goal was to immerse myself in the entrepreneurial experience and build my own track record, and that's exactly what I achieved. I gained invaluable insights into financial management and built a solid foundation for my career as a hedge fund manager, all of which I proudly share in my book.

My entrepreneurial path taught me that launching a business in the competitive financial sector demands not only intelligence but also patience, perseverance, and self-belief. These lessons propelled me forward through all types of adversity in life. This journey cemented my passion for investing and bolstered my confidence in my ability to grow wealth and eventually managing my own capital in my own capacity. I can proclaim that this passion is ingrained in me, and I will enjoy it for the rest of my life.

Looking back, I realized that starting my own hedge fund was not just about making money; it was about challenging myself, taking risks, and pursuing my dreams. I gained a sense of empowerment from knowing that I took control of my own destiny and learned so much about myself and my capabilities in the process. It has taught me valuable lessons that I will carry with me throughout my life and has shaped me into a more seasoned and adept investor.

After six years of running my own hedge fund, I was able to walk away from the experience feeling fulfilled and empowered. By then, I had learned so much about myself and what it takes to run a business, and I carried that mindset and experience with me to my next job in London as a portfolio manager in a multi-billion-dollar hedge fund. At the end, I still ended up where I would've been had I chosen option 1 in 2009, except I made less money but gained invaluable experiences that I can look back on and be genuinely proud of and share with my children and grandchildren. Some people may call me a fool for taking a circuitous path to get to the

destination, but I beg to differ. In fact, this path made me appreciate life and the world better. Had I gone straight, I would've missed out on all the beautiful flowers and animals in the garden.

During my two years in London working in the hedge fund industry, I developed my knowledge and honed my skills as an investor even further until the company shut down and I got laid off again. From there, I found my next challenge - working for a single-family office in Singapore.

Moving to London in 2015 and then Singapore in 2017 were both huge leaps for me personally and professionally. But I was ready for the challenge, and I embraced it with open arms. I had the skills and experience necessary to thrive, and I was confident in my ability to adapt to new environments and cultures. I wanted to be in the Huntsman Program to be truly global, and I was fulfilling that destiny by having worked extensively on 4 continents.

Looking back, I am grateful for all the lessons I have learned and the experiences I have gained

on this journey. Getting laid off is a risk employees often don't factor in in their decision making. Never get laid off is actually uncommon, but employees think that's the norm and benefit of working for somebody. Starting my own business wasn't just a career choice; it was a way of life. It instilled in me a sense of independence and fearlessness. Most importantly, it had given me a taste of what real purpose and freedom means.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Career Pivot from Finance to Preschool

When my wife and I left London for Singapore in early 2017, we had our first child at thirty-eight years old. Having a child really changed my perspective of life because that was when time and freedom mattered most to me. I wanted to be next to my children as they grew up and be as involved as possible in their upbringing. I was ambivalent because I didn't want my kids to go through the same struggle my parents and I did, yet at the same time I know it's beneficial to them. Having kids made me realize that time really is limited and that it passes by faster than I could imagine. In our case, it was extraordinary because we had undergone multiple miscarriages. No doctor could explain why, and such mysteries reminded me that money is not a panacea. Again, life is fragile, and some things are out of our control regardless of how hard we yearn for it. For example, there was nothing I could've done to prevent myself from being laid off twice.

Therefore, in aspects where we can take control of our lives, don't hold back.

With that backdrop, the pursuit of freedom and managing my own schedule became my priority. I knew that I needed to be my own boss again and steer my life towards that goal before I turned forty. By the time I turned forty, I didn't need to reach my destination but just wanted to be on a clear path to take full control of my life and not rely on anyone for a paycheck to make ends meet or work tirelessly day and night for someone else to take the credit. I wanted to do things at my own time and convenience. That way, I would allocate time to doing things that I truly value – take ownership of my own life by spending quality time with my loved ones while building things I find meaningful and continue investing.

Growing up in Hong Kong with my family, I barely saw my parents. They spent most of their time at work. My sister and I were raised by my grandmother. We would see our parents on weekends. Once we immigrated to the US, I saw my father twice a year until I moved back to

Hong Kong 18 years later. It was my mother who physically took care of us. She didn't know how to drive or cook, but once we were in the US, we were on our own. She got a driver's license and learned to cook for us. My sister and I did the housework and repaired broken items at home.

The distance with my father didn't really affect our relationship. I actually admired his sacrifice in raising us, but I couldn't imagine myself working harder towards someone else's dream than spending time with my loved ones. It was actually an eye-opener because it made me realize that one day I would become a father myself and when that happens, I would want to have the flexibility to do what I want and also decide what I use my time for.

After two years of working in the family office, I decided to leave and start another venture which was to own and manage preschools in Singapore. I had always been interested in education because, to me, it didn't end in school. Education is a lifelong experience and is something that takes place in every aspect of our lives as there's always something to learn from the next person.

We all went through some kind of education during our careers. I've been trained by other people, incredible mentors who pass down the knowledge they have acquired not just by going to school and getting a degree but mostly by the practical knowledge and boardroom battles they had undergone through years of working. I've also trained many people, juniors who became seniors and the chain continues just like that. The takeaway in all these was that each mentor passed the baton to the younger generation to reach their milestone. They saved me a lot of time to help me get to where I wanted to be. I really appreciated that and would love to do the same for others. So, for me, getting into the education industry was my calling.

A Leap of Faith

To rewind back a couple years to 2016 before I took this leap of faith to permanently leave investment management as a full-time career, I did spend a lot of time thinking about what to do outside of finance, weighing the pros and cons of a career pivot. It was daunting to pursue something I had no prior experience in so

what I did first was to speak to countless people in different industries. I spoke to people who were in technology, sales, and hospitality. I targeted people who had made a career switch and those who made less money to find out what life was like when you earned less. What is life like without all the glamour and senior title next to my business card? How will others perceive me? Because now I have my wife and kids to support, I needed to map out a budget so that while I explore new ventures, I would also have enough for my family. It was a critical crossroad in life, but thankfully I had the luxury and time to do thorough research. I modeled out multiple scenarios to budget how much I needed each year, especially if things went sour. My wife didn't come from finance and told me it's fine we don't make as much money. I learned that those who appeared to have less "glamorous" jobs or titles and made less money were just as happy or happier than I was. At the end of this self-discovery, I realized that it all came down to mindset and lifestyle. It was my own mental state and expectations that I had to overcome.

We all have different paths to getting to a destination, and that path really matters because it determines if the foundation you lay is strong enough to withstand bumps along the way. Despite being laid off twice in the past, I strongly believed that I was better than a lot of people both financially and work ethic, so why can't I do something while others can? A lot of people can't make their career pivot in life because of the doubts that set in each time they think of venturing into a new career or business path. We feel trapped because we are conditioned to think that our job description and resume define what we can do. Many tend to dim the ideas that light up in their minds because they are trained to expect a pay raise or a promotion if they put in the time. That's the definition of corporate ladder. In finance, if you put in x number of years, you should make VP, Director, MD or Partner, etc. They fear that if they get off this ladder for something else, then they have to start from the bottom, or somebody would occupy their spot on the ladder.

I did a lot of soul searching before I pivoted my career into the idea of owning preschools. At first, I asked myself; how do I get into this space? If I didn't have a full-time finance job, what else could I do? What skills do I possess that will allow me to switch careers? What can I do that is more meaningful so I can give back to society and still be able to invest at the same time? Being in finance full-time wasn't really as fulfilling anymore because now I felt like there was something more meaningful out there than to always think about how to make money. Despite how passionate I am about investing, I wanted to make a real impact on society. But 2018 wasn't the same as when I started my hedge fund 9 years earlier. This time I was approaching the peak of my career in a cushy job that many envied. It was comfortable. This time, I actually had a family and more obligations to fulfill. The opportunity cost was way higher because it wasn't all about me anymore. I had dependents that I needed to think about each time I made a financial decision. I needed health insurance for the family. If I leave this cushy job, I may never be able to find one like this.

At the same time, I looked into the mirror and the person looking back at me told me I was not fulfilled waking up doing what I was about to do. I felt empty. For the first time in my life, I was not inspired to wake up to go to work despite it being the most comfortable. Somehow these concerns turned into timely opportunities to open new doors.

Because of my little one, I looked at a lot of preschools in Singapore, thinking of a place I could possibly send my child to study and realized that I didn't like any of them. I just didn't believe in their philosophy. I knew my wife and I could do better with our knowledge and experience, so I thought of homeschooling. However, the more schools I visited, the more confident I was that I could run these schools better than whomever the owners were. What if I started a better preschool for my own child and impacted her classmates at the same time? It would also be a means for me to leverage my skills in finance. That's killing multiple birds with one stone! And that's the premise to moving into the early childhood industry in Singapore.

Challenging my Doubts

Each time I get scared of taking a risk or I find myself in a critical junction, I always ask myself rhetorical questions; am I the only person who is faced with this issue? If not, how then do those people who have faced it overcome it? When you figure out people who have similar challenges as you do and how they overcame them, the next step becomes easy. It's like fledglings that take their first leap of faith and jump off the cliff. They observe their parents, then one jumps and the others follow suit.

If I was to invent something that didn't exist, it would be a different case as I would have nobody with prior knowledge to learn from or guide me. But many have had career pivots and found it to be fulfilling. Like starting my own hedge fund, I knew many failed but I focused on the successes. Why not me? I had a lot more reasons to answer "Yes" than "No." This gave me the confidence boost I needed to resign from my cushy family office job.

For one, I would say that I possess very broad and useful experience, having worked for more than twenty years in fast-paced environments that fully utilized my skills. Above all, I started my own hedge fund at 30 years old. I think my work ethic, discipline, and ability to deal with setbacks and get out of my comfort zone are in the top few percent of the human population. A lot of people would think that the job experience in finance is not transferable and that is completely understandable. I mean I'm just a numbers guy, right? I've spent most of my time in front of a screen, thinking of how to make money by investing in businesses operated by others. What do I know about operating and scaling an actual business and leading people? But to be honest, the finance experience is very transferable. The truth is people who excel in finance are analytical, adaptive and hardworking go-getters. That already increases their chances of success in anything. Moreover, any successful business owner needs to understand concepts such as return on investments, return on capital, and return on effort; while this may seem like a piece of cake for those in finance, many entrepreneurs

without finance background actually don't understand them. This is something I never appreciated until I could look from the outside as a business operator and investor. Being a former investment banker and private equity investor, I learned to bring large groups of people together through the life cycle of deals. I believed I had an edge because I helped scale an auto dealership portfolio company during my private equity days. So going into the preschool industry, I had a hunch that all these experiences would be useful; the beautiful part of the whole experience was that as I deployed capital into preschools, I could continue my passion of investing while being my own boss on my own terms. More importantly, I was investing in myself by acquiring new knowledge. Thus, starting preschool was just another way for me to invest in a less conventional manner. In so many ways, I was doing everything I already enjoyed but in a more impactful and tangible manner. The icing on the cake for this second venture was that I did not have to use other people's money. I simply made use of the wealth I accumulated and properly

leveraged the skills I had built up over the years to pursue my goal.

One of the key reasons why I started preschool was so I could educate my kids exactly the way I wanted to. I didn't want to send my kids off to another school to learn and live by someone else's philosophy that I didn't resonate with. I would run the school according to my own philosophy and on my own terms. Therefore, regardless of how this business turned out financially, I could treat this as a gift my wife and I would give to our kids.

Another thing people talk about when it comes to starting a business is the opportunity cost. Of course, you have to weigh what you gain and what you lose. How much money do I need to invest, especially considering the fact that I do not get a steady paycheck? Of course, I did not get a paycheck when I first started, just like when I launched my hedge fund. My wife had no income either. I had to risk my own capital to buy mom-and-pop preschools and build them into a corporation. While it wasn't easy to take these risks, I recall I had bet on myself at 30 years old

when I had a lot less. This time I was motivated by my child, passion for education and disseminating knowledge just as others had done for me. By replicating even a sliver of what I had done in private equity and applying my hedge fund investor mindset, I will be just fine. And I know by putting in the effort, passion and love for my child and her classmates, clients will endorse this business, and I will ultimately be rewarded financially. With this mindset, I was already a winner before I even started.

Leveraging Skills

I bought my first preschool in 2018, about two years after my move to Singapore. It gave me so much joy to actually see my dreams turn into reality. After that I continued to buy or build one preschool every year, increasing my rate of deploying capital. This was exactly what I was doing in my private equity days except I was using someone else's money to do roll-ups.

Having run my own hedge fund, I had already developed the mindset that it is normal to risk most of my own wealth, putting money where

my mouth was. Of course, every difficulty and challenge were now amplified because this was not something I was doing with a team initially. It was easier when I was employed by a company because the decision didn't solely rest on me, and I had more experienced colleagues that could easily tackle a situation. There were ample resources to tap into. Now I had to work on my own and solely make decisions that might make me or mar me. There was no other shareholder to opine on or share a different view about how things could be done better. I had to build up the key systems, the legal framework and the entire infrastructure. Every dollar spent was from my pocket. I had to bear every mistake on my own with nobody else to share the blame. Having said that, everything I had learned before became useful.

Every preschool I ever bought and sold was solely diligenced, negotiated and financed by me. I basically did everything on my own terms and conditions including the legal contracts and financial analysis. It wasn't exactly rocket science for me because I've done it repeatedly in my

former jobs and I applied those experiences to my own benefit. Again, the years of putting in the hard work and consistently going to work, to have somebody pay me to learn and expand my skill set was not wasted.

I would also like to talk about the value of leveraging our network. I can't overemphasize how important it is that you bond with people professionally. It gives you the opportunity to market your area of expertise and associate with people who expand your market. Networking is underrated because we are programmed to think we can do things on our own. The need to network is usually not stated in our job description or resume. Ultimately in any business regardless of industry, there is always a buyer and a seller of a product or service. A useful network will help you connect the dots with these participants. It is important to invest the time to network effectively in any field you are in. By going to work and engaging with people around you, I would say that you're building immeasurable long-term value for yourself. Sometimes you might not appreciate that until

you leave the industry. I can boldly say that during my preschool venture, I received tremendous advice and support from people that I've come across during my finance days. Some of the buyers of my preschools were referred to me by those whom I knew from finance. After leaving the family office, I became an investor in private equity funds and multi-family offices, which I got to know when I was working in the family office, as I was building the preschool. They proactively introduced me to buyers when they heard I was looking to exit the business. If I had never worked in finance, made the effort to network with people and be kind to them, it wouldn't have been as easy to find buyers and sellers or people who would just in general support me.

Referrals are highly valuable as you may not have the contacts you need to catapult your business to the next level. Referrals put you in a stronger position than just a random seller spamming the inbox of the potential buyer. Worst is relying on agents who only care about getting a deal done and getting paid, so they treat you just like every

other buyer or seller and give you open-ended recommendations. Thus, when you think of solely focusing on your work and minding your business, I'll advise you to take a step back and look at the bigger picture. Then you will realize how valuable some intangible things truly are.

The Exit

Before I even started, I had envisioned the type of exit I wanted. From day 1, I structured my business to consummate such a scenario. Thanks for having been in private equity. This time was different from when I started my hedge fund because I was more seasoned and well-prepared.

In my case, I engineered my own exit by finding a buyer through my finance network that was established over many years. I managed my own sale process from start to finish including putting together the PowerPoint presentation, financial projections and data room. I handled due diligence and the negotiation of legal documents. There couldn't have been a better conclusion to this chapter of my life than what has transpired. All the dots connected, and pieces fell into place

after leveraging nearly two decades worth of work experience.

When I purchased my first school in October of 2018, it was just five months before my first child enrolled in preschool. By the time I exited the business was around when my first child graduated from preschool. As she walked across the stage to receive her diploma during her graduation ceremony, tears almost streamed down my face as it marked a significant milestone – my original mission of giving my kid an education I believed in was accomplished. Despite all the tribulations of having panic attacks where I broke down and cried like a little baby in front of my young children and wife and having chest pains when I thought I would have a heart attack triggered by running the business, I looked around the packed auditorium and noticed that my philosophy had impacted the lives of many children and been endorsed by parents that grew almost 10x from the day I started. Financially, I feel I was fairly rewarded for the work that was put into serving my mission. Everything was worth it.

Now I can proudly claim I had a successful exit from my second venture. It gave me so much joy that I could say to myself, I started this five years ago with a mere belief, a belief that I would one day write about the finale of this startup and career pivot. Now, I can resoundingly say that the belief was not just a fantasy but a true story. I know sometimes we fail and most times we doubt our ability to execute certain ideas, but we have to ask ourselves; why can't we do this when others can? What I've learned at work, why is it not useful? What is my purpose for going to work? Why can't I do something different? To those asking these questions to let me remind them that I had no prior experience of how to run a preschool and it was a complete career switch for me, but yet I pulled it off simply because I believed the dots would connect. Merely by leveraging the skills I built up in my career and applied them to something less obvious, I can attest that whatever skills we have can be transferred regardless of how elusive that may seem. We can always acquire new skills along the way.

Reflecting on the journey and the eventual outcome, I am fulfilled and complete.

Now onto coaching and mentoring those high-achieving individuals, soon to be leaders or current leaders but still seeking breakthroughs within their careers, aggregating all my experiences as leverage marks another exciting chapter in life's journey.

CHAPTER NINE

Sitting on Boards

I had been away from being employed as a full-time investor as I was building my preschool and the events that followed were a rollercoaster. I wasn't really thinking that a new door in finance would open up to me but then it did.

It so happened that at that time, some of my friends and acquaintances would come to me seeking counsel and guidance on launching their own hedge funds. Investment banks that I had worked with still referred their clients to me as I was more than willing to share my experience of starting and running a hedge fund. Because many people helped me along the way, I always enjoyed sharing my knowledge and inspiring others as I embraced the role of mentor with zeal. Little did I know that this casual engagement would evolve into a new avenue of professional pursuit.

One day, I was talking to a friend at an investment bank, and she causally suggested: “You are so excited when you talk about your past experience of running a fund. Why not explore the role of an independent director?” I had gotten so used to sharing my knowledge about hedge funds to people that I soon forgot that I was distributing value. It was a revelation, a light bulb moment that illuminated a path I had never considered. With the wisdom of hindsight, I realized the value of my own experiences in building businesses, coupled with the fact that I had sat on multiple sides of the table within asset management, would allow me to offer unique perspectives as a director.

Again, through referrals from my network, I was able to find myself seated at the table of governance, lending my expertise and insight into a diverse array of hedge funds and private equity vehicles. It was clear that my days of managing third-party capital to expand my finance network were not essential; but now my new role as director has afforded me a new sense of purpose and fulfillment.

As peers and clients looked to me for guidance and leadership, I have a newfound sense of respect and admiration. It was a humbling experience, one that underscored the transformative power of reinvention and resilience. I am again gifted with excellent mentors and service providers to guide me.

So, what exactly does it mean to be an independent director of funds? In simple terms, it means ensuring the fund vehicle is compliant, following the guidelines of what it promised its investors. And if we are to be inspected by the regulators, the board is to ensure that all will be fine. Unlike executive directors who might have personal interest in the fund's management, independent directors are unbiased and bring fresh perspectives.

One of the main jobs of an independent director is to protect investors by making sure the fund is transparent, accountable, and follows the rules set by regulators. He keeps an eye on how the fund operates, its investors, the investments it makes, and how it manages risks to avoid conflicts of interest.

Being an independent director comes with its perks. You get to see the big picture by sitting at the top of the organization chart. You can still be in the loop without having to worry about market volatility. You can learn from intelligent investors what they think about the world and where they are deploying capital. You get paid for your expertise and the responsibilities you take on. More importantly, you are still in the game learning and expanding your network. The downside, however, is you are personally liable if anything goes wrong.

On a personal level, being an independent director gives me a sense of fulfillment. I am in the forefront of ensuring the financial industry operates smoothly and investors are protected. As an entrepreneur and business builder, I enjoy going the extra mile to help my clients grow their businesses and be their sounding board. I can empathize with them because I used to be in their shoes. It requires honesty, hard work, and a commitment to the highest ethical standards. I always kept these things in mind because at this point, I was thinking more about legacy than

money. For example, while some people may perceive independent directors as “rubber stampers,” my colleagues and I are definitely not one of them. We are diligent and take full ownership of our work, thoroughly reading every document line by line and fully embracing the fact that every signature has serious legal repercussions. Furthermore, our team goes the extra mile to help our clients scale their businesses.

For four and a half years and counting, I have walked this path of directorship, each day bringing new challenges, lessons and triumphs. My reputation has grown. My network has expanded. It is a journey that defies expectations, a testament to the unpredictable nature of destiny.

As I reflect on this part of my life, I see how the dots are connected. We face many crossroads, but somehow different paths merge to take us to our dream destination. Had I not started my own hedge fund, worked with investment banks and had coffee with my friend who triggered this light bulb, this door would not have been there for me

to open. What started as a hobby became my profession, showing how important it is to take chances and try new things.

CHAPTER TEN

Why Businesses Fail

In the world of finance, we often hear iconic figures like Warren Buffet and Charlie Munger talking about what makes a great business. But as someone who has been both an investor and operator of successful and not so successful businesses and ventured into entrepreneurship myself, I've learned that the key to understanding why businesses fail often boils down to one crucial factor: people.

Have the Right Team

The most critical aspect of any business is having the right team in place. Leadership is the secret ingredient to success. A good leader articulates the vision clearly and rallies the team behind common goals. That's why the senior management team is so vital — they set the tone and direction for the entire organization. A superstar cannot win an NBA championship without the proper roster and coach.

Alignment of Interest

Another crucial element is ensuring alignment among all stakeholders, including shareholders and managers. If conflicts of interest arise, it can spell trouble for the business. Leaders with conflicting interests may not make the best decision for stakeholders.

When it comes down to it, I believe that investing in a company with great people and leaders trumps investing in a company with a stellar product but mediocre people. It's like the analogy of giving a Ferrari to someone who can't drive — it's bound to end in disaster. On the other hand, a skilled driver can make do with a jalopy and still reach his destination, albeit with some bumps along the way.

In the end, the success or failure of a business hinges on the people behind it. It's about having the right leadership, a unified team, and a shared vision that propels the company forward despite any obstacles that may arise along the way. Thus, I believe that businesses can succeed as long as you have the right people.

Sales and Marketing

In the world of business, having a fantastic product isn't enough on its own. Without strong sales and marketing efforts, even the best products can go unnoticed. I've learned this firsthand from starting two businesses.

Imagine you've created something amazing — a product that could change lives. But if no one knows about it, its brilliance goes unseen. If your product isn't incredibly unique and in high demand, solely relying on its greatness may not ensure a successful strategy. Competition is always looming, ready to take your limelight. One valuable lesson I learned from running my hedge fund is that I needed to look at it more like a business than a vehicle to generate profits. How do I publicize and market this product to investors? How do I differentiate myself from others?

Moving into sales and marketing requires a different way of thinking. It's about understanding people — what they want, what they need, and how they think. This shift in

mindset is crucial for connecting with customers on a personal level and addressing their concerns. As someone who's more used to dealing with numbers and data, I've come to recognize that sales and marketing is all about human psychology. It takes facts and figures and turn them into stories that resonate with people.

In essence, sales and marketing is the heartbeat of any successful business. By embracing the power of sales and marketing, businesses can thrive, build relationships, and stand out in a crowded marketplace.

Financial Discipline

In the world of business, knowing how much and when to invest is a game changer. Over my career, I've seen two common mistakes owners make with money. Firstly, some owners don't invest enough. They're too careful and end up not spending what's needed to reach their goals. As a result, they fall short and struggle to make progress.

On the other hand, some owners invest too much. They spend a lot but don't get enough

back in return. They hire too many people or spend on things they don't need, which can hurt the business in the long run. This often happens when a company raises a lot of external capital.

Due to my privileged background as an investor, I was able to think about basic return on investment concept when running my preschool. What is the return on each dollar spent on social media? What is the return generated on each dollar of the promotion and discount offered?

It's important to find the right balance. Every dollar spent should be thoughtfully considered, with a clear idea of what it will bring in return. By making smart financial decisions, businesses can grow steadily and avoid unnecessary risks. Financial prudence is key to long-term success in the business world.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Lessons from Mentors

My very first mentors were my paternal grandmother and father. They were a big part of my life, not just as a mentor but also as a confidant. I had spoken earlier about how they weren't very educated but were so full of wisdom and knowledge. They knew that there were a lot of things they would have wanted to do, but they just didn't have the time or ability to do it. Since then, they made it their life mission to guide and point me in the right direction.

My dad taught me so many key lessons but one that greatly influenced my life was the lesson he taught me very early on that everybody must have a sense of urgency and fear because if you don't have that, you would never attempt to reach for your dreams.

If you're always comfortable, you will never want to pursue the next thing. You end up settling. You lack hunger. For him, his sense of fear came from the fact that he was very poor and uneducated,

not having food on the table and a place to live, in addition to knowing he would never get a promotion in the workplace.

His fear of not being able to crack the ceiling was what made him become entrepreneurial. At the same time, he told me that he didn't want me to take over a small family business. He always believed that I could be more and pave my own path. "You have many paths to explore," he would say. And this was uncommon for Asian families. A lot of Asian families wanted their kids to take over their business, whatever that may be, and if they refused, it could even cause a rift in the family. It was a thing of honor. It was a duty. But my dad was like, "Look, son, you're going to be a lot more educated, and you should explore bigger and better things. So, don't ever expect to just take over what daddy or mommy has for you."

My dad had his glory moments and defeats. Regardless, he raised me and my sister well. You've got to be proud of that.

My mother taught me to work hard first on whatever is important before playing. As a result,

I am not a procrastinator. I don't party and then rush home to write my class paper 12 hours before it's due. I would always study and do my homework first before I play. I learned to prioritize and focus. That's how I can work hard and play even harder later. I would thank my parents a billion times over for the mindset ingrained in me. I always knew that I didn't have a safety net if I decided to not do anything with my life. There wasn't some big family business waiting for me to milk. My parents didn't have anything to take over from my grandparents, so I wasn't expecting to have anything from them. The result was that I have lived my life with a sense of urgency. Not once did they check my report card or interfere with my academics. Never did they micromanage me to take classes because they knew the values they instilled in me were enough for me to propel myself forward. They never really had expectations of me as long as I became a good person and lived a happy life. That lack of pressure and expectation gave me the liberty to aim high. Instead, they would remind me to slow down and the importance of health.

Another class of mentors I had was my bosses at different companies. It was as though they were hand-picked and sent to me. I grew tremendously under them. Below are the lessons learned from each of them.

Check the Numbers

At my first job after college, Credit Suisse. The thing I remember most is they always remind me of the number one rule and that is “check the numbers to make sure it's right.” I reckoned that this was because that was my job as an analyst, and the numbers just got to be right! But there was a deeper reason behind their actions.

No. 1

It's important to do your homework and know your data. When you present accurate numbers, people are more likely to trust and rely on you and if you don't have that trust and reliability, you can't go far in life.

No.2

Diligence! Attention to detail! That's what checking the numbers imparted to me. I followed through with the process and it further built my resolve against mediocrity.

People Matter

In private equity, my boss wouldn't stop telling me that it's all about relationships. It's about people. It's about bonding and getting to know people because why would people single you out when they might have a closer and better option? When you see everyone wanting to invest in a company, we need to make sure that we are well-received — others need to be comfortable around us.

Knowledge is Not Enough

When I switched from private equity to hedge fund, my bosses would tell me, look, you're still very young, you might think you're smart. You think you may know a lot, but it doesn't make you a good investor and a good fund manager.

Why?

Because being smart is not equivalent to being able to take risks. Being smart also is not equivalent to being decisive and emotionally resilient. And that's why public market investing, and hedge funds are not for everybody. It's not for people who simply think they are smart.

In public market investing, being decisive is crucial for success. Unlike making deals, which can take years to unfold, investing in stocks provides quicker feedback on whether your decisions are right or wrong. With tens of thousands of investment opportunities available, the responsibility lies in choosing the right ones.

For me, being decisive has been instrumental in my journey, especially in starting my own businesses. As a leader, I believe in making decisions firmly and without regrets, even if they may turn out to be wrong. Indecisiveness can lead to confusion and lack of direction, whereas clear yes or no answers provide clarity and direction to the team. Being decisive is a prerequisite to being a capable leader.

Decisiveness isn't about always being right; it's about making choices based on available information. We will never obtain all the information we want. Even when uncertain, I acknowledge it and seek the necessary data points to make as informed a decision as possible. I'm grateful for mentors who instilled this value in me early on, recognizing its importance in navigating the complexities of the world.

Leaders Listen More Than They Talk

My bosses taught me the real leader in the room should be the one who speaks last and the least. A leader is to empower their followers and seek input to make impactful decisions. True leaders don't need to justify their existence and value by how much they talk, but rather what they say. While they may say little, whatever they say shall impress its audience. This reminds me of an orchestra conductor. The conductor rarely speaks but rather allows musicians to shine at the right moments. He maintains harmony and flow. However, when the conductor speaks, the entire orchestra stops and is silent. Every musician is listening with undivided attention.

International Exposure

I spent one and a half years in Australia from 2004 to 2005 and about 10 years covering China from 2006 to 2015. My experience in Australia was quite different from my time in China.

During my time in Australia, I was constantly on the move. Every Sunday night, I boarded a plane from Hong Kong for a nine-hour red-eye flight to either Melbourne or Sydney, landing at 6 a.m. local time. After a quick stop at the hotel to freshen up, I headed straight to the office by 9 a.m. and worked tirelessly throughout the week.

On Fridays, I repeated the process in reverse, catching the 11:30 p.m. flight back to Hong Kong, arriving at 6 a.m. on Saturday and heading straight to the office again. This routine persisted for a year and a half, during which I travelled between Hong Kong, Australia, and New Zealand approximately 24 times. I became a premium member with airlines and hotels, enjoying the perks that came with frequent travel.

At the time, it felt like an adventure, being recognized as a premium member by flight attendants and even pilots. However, reflecting on it now, I realize the toll it took, and the sacrifices made for my work, even at a young age.

After some time, I began to question the lifestyle I was leading. Reflecting on it, I realized that I had spent more nights on a plane and hotel than my own bed. True, they were business class flights and luxurious hotels, but I started to wonder if this was what I truly wanted in life.

However, being in my twenties and single, I had no family or obligations tying me down. It provided a solid foundation for me to build upon. I was getting paid to travel in style. I was working on landmark deals. But it prompted me to ponder the value of life itself.

As I entered my forties and even my late thirties, I barely traveled except for holidays. I gained control over my schedule, unlike some of my peers who still travelled extensively and enjoyed premium status with airlines and hotels. I, on the other hand, have no status in anything. No

lounge access, no priority seating. Yet, I wasn't envious of others with status because I knew achieving it often required sacrifices.

For me, having control over my schedule and the freedom to say no to things became more valuable. I had paid my dues in my early years, and now I could shape my life according to my desires.

China was another intriguing chapter in my life. I began working there around the end of 2005, and from early 2006 onwards, I focused on building my career in both private and public investing within China.

The early to mid-2000s marked the rise of China as a global superpower. I was fortunate to witness this transformation firsthand, sitting at the forefront of China's ascent. Working for a well-established US global institution provided me with invaluable resources and networks. Despite being relatively young, people looked up to me simply because of the company I represented. I found myself in meetings with

senior executives and CEOs who had power, expertise and influence.

I often had to meet them alone or with a small team, representing my company. Despite my youth, my position demanded that I step up to the challenge. I had to rely on my Mandarin skills, which I had started learning at the age of 10. In China, Mandarin was the primary language, and I had to use it extensively for work. Learning Mandarin was a journey I embarked on early in life, driven by my passion for learning and dedication to languages. Today I speak four languages. Above all, I thank my parents for having foresight. They knew that if I wanted to be in Asia one day and witness the rise of China, I had to know Mandarin.

Back then, we didn't have tools like Google Translate, so I always carried a dictionary with me. In my free time whether on a plane or lunch break, I immersed myself in the Chinese language, memorizing the dictionary to better navigate the demands of my job. Similarly, when I was growing up in the US, I did the same to learn English by memorizing the dictionary.

Working in private equity was a pivotal time for me, especially in terms of learning the intricacies of business negotiations and legal documentation, particularly in China. My firm's presence in China meant that legal and financial documents had to be bilingual, both in Chinese and English, to accommodate our American background.

This requirement provided me with a unique opportunity to learn Chinese firsthand. I would meticulously compare English and Chinese versions of legal documents side by side, helping with translations and understanding the nuances of each language. I was able to negotiate and review legal documents confidently in both English and Chinese, a skill I honed during my time there.

I had the chance to shadow lawyers during negotiations, observing their strategies and techniques firsthand. It was a valuable learning experience, facilitated by the opportunities provided by my employer and the top-quality service providers it hired.

These experiences laid the groundwork for many of my future endeavors, including ventures into preschool business and company acquisitions. The skills and knowledge I acquired during my mid-twenties continue to shape my approach to business and negotiations to this day.

I am deeply thankful to all my incredible mentors.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Conclusion

Life's Fragility and Avoiding Regrets

Throughout my life, I have always held onto the belief that living without regret is the best way to live. This perspective was shaped by two significant events that occurred early on in my life, both of which had the potential to end my life. The first event was undergoing surgery myself, a daunting experience that made me realize how precious life truly is. Prior to the operation at 6 years old, I had blood draws and injections regularly. Needles, blood and I became friends. I was always attached to some machine. The second event was being a few feet away from the death of my friend from a fatal car accident and subsequently watching him being laid to rest at just 16 years old. These experiences left an indelible mark on me and made me acutely aware of how tangible death can be.

As a result, I have made it a priority to live without regret as much as possible. Many young

people tend to think that such an outlook doesn't apply to them; however, I believe it is very applicable and realistic. Life is unpredictable, and we never know what tomorrow may bring. Therefore, it's essential to make every moment count and not waste time on things that won't matter in the long run.

Living without regret means different things for different people. For some, it may mean pursuing their passions or taking risks they wouldn't normally take. For others, it may mean spending more time with loved ones or travelling to new places. It generally has to do with what you value most in life. Whatever it means for you personally, the point is not to let fear hold you back from living your best life.

My experiences have taught me that life is precious and fleeting, and we should strive to live without regrets as much as possible. It's never too early or too late to adopt this mindset and start making positive changes in your life today.

Consequently, death became a more concrete concept for me, despite its morbid nature. As

such, I am adamant about living life without any regrets if possible. This conviction is grounded in the understanding that mortality is not just an abstract notion but a real possibility; young people often tend to overlook this fact and believe it does not apply to them. If given the chance to redo certain things, I acknowledge that some of my past actions were impulsive and not something I would want to see my children do.

Perhaps in my earlier days, I struggled with managing my temper and competitiveness. I was a sore loser. As a result, there were instances where hurtful words were said towards others. How I expressed frustration towards people is not behavior that I would want future generations to emulate. Over time, I've learned that true strength and virtue lie not in victory, but in the grace with which you handle defeat. My mom would always teach me 失败乃是成功之母 or "Failure is the mother of success." There are actions that I regret having done. But I know I am not perfect and always strive to improve. Despite any regrets from a personal standpoint, career-wise, even having been laid-off twice, I am

extremely grateful for all the doors I have walked through thus far.

It is common for individuals to measure success based on financial gain; however, money alone does not define true success. One can possess vast wealth without holding the title of the wealthiest individual. Even if my wealth had more zeros attached to it, it would not alter the quality of life experienced today. It doesn't add to my happiness. My needs are minimalistic. Therefore, acquiring material possessions holds little importance as everything necessary is already obtained. In fact, even if an infinite amount of money was at hand, its abundance would be meaningless as all desired items have already been purchased through prior means.

I appreciate the fact that my parents taught me early on that health is the most important thing because we cannot bring money with us (to our graves). 钱是帶不走的. It's not something you would teach a child, but that's what my parents told me when I was only in intermediate school. They tell me this so I can be more grounded and down to earth.

However, one thing remains heavy on my heart - the passing of my grandmother, in 2019. Her influence on shaping who I am today cannot be understated or forgotten. She will forever hold a special place within me; her memory is alive through cherished moments shared together over time spent building lifelong connections between us both. A significant portion of my personal growth is attributed to the influence and values instilled in me by my grandmother. The memory of speaking to her on the phone on 13 March 2019 when she was hospitalized in Hong Kong remains vivid in my mind. While we spoke on my way to a lunch in Singapore, she was so full of life and there was an excitement in her tone that was infectious, but I abruptly ended our conversation as I walked into a restaurant thinking I can speak to her later and see her in person in a week. I am sure the conversation could have stretched on for hours if I hadn't cut her off.

Later that night when we spoke again, she was lethargic. Given this observation, we ended the conversation quickly so she could rest.

Tragically just hours later came the news of my beloved grandma's passing in her sleep which left an indelible mark upon both me and those closest to us all alike. The shock of learning about such a sudden loss quickly led me into reflecting deeply upon past actions, wondering if there might be anything more--what I could've done differently or if any regrets weighed heavy within my heart now.

Specifically recalling one instance where despite knowing very well how important staying connected with loved ones is especially during times like these, yet I chose to prioritize attending some mundane lunch over talking to her. Even now I can't remember whom I had lunch with or whether such a lunch even took place. The only thing I am certain about is I regret not having made the most out of the opportunity presented, not spending precious moments conversing with her. I will always remember I squandered the final chance to have a lucid conversation with my beloved grandma.

Reflecting on life's fragility, I recall the years spent apart from my parents and grandmother as

an expat for most of my life. It is then that I remind myself how fleeting life can be, particularly for elderly individuals. Time, especially for those who are older, is undoubtedly more limited than it is for their younger counterparts.

I wish that during her passing moments, I was by my grandmother's side. It pains me to think about hanging up on her without even a proper farewell when I had the opportunity because we cannot take anything for granted in this world. We may not believe today could be our last, but it could be someone else's; that someone could be our dearly beloved.

It is only when things like this happen that we realize that time never reverses and that the past can't be changed. These experiences have molded me into who I am today, and it has helped me take charge of my own life. Being in charge of the decisions I make enables me to say "no" to others while prioritizing quality time with myself, my loved ones and things I value most in life.

My appreciation and admiration towards cherished relationships leave no room or patience for nonsense because I understand how valuable time truly is. As Steve Jobs said “Time is limited, so don't waste it living someone else's life. Don't be trapped by dogma - which is living with the results of other people's thinking. Don't let the noise of others' opinions drown out your own inner voice. And most importantly, have the courage to follow your heart and intuition.” Therefore, I will not live anyone else's life but mine alone. I now live my life prioritizing spending quality time with people whom I love and care about so much more than before.

Lessons in Leadership and Work Life

Getting to where I am today, I've gathered a wealth of knowledge from being a junior employee to a partner-level executive to starting my own business, to running it, ensuring its growth through lots of perseverance and challenges that threatened its survival.

Over the past five years, while building my preschool, I have also taken on other

engagements. Specifically, I continued to compound my capital and served on the boards of companies. Due to my past experiences, I had the privilege to educate and train others on how to enhance their performance at work or hone those in senior-level roles to be better leaders. The knowledge and skills I gained from running my own firms are highly valued by others because they recognize that I have been there and done that. Moreover, when I give advice, I am willing to put money where my mouth is.

The journey of starting an entire firm is no easy feat. It involves navigating through various crises, difficulties, and challenges that test one's resilience and fortitude. As a business owner or financier, one must be prepared to face the ups and downs that come with running a successful enterprise. Additionally, running a brick-and-mortar, labor intensive business requires a different set of skills and knowledge than that of an investor. One must understand how to train staff members effectively, empower employees to reach their full potential and develop leadership skills that inspire others to follow suit. In essence,

being a successful business owner requires a deep understanding of the mindset of entrepreneurs and financiers alike, the customers, and the employees as well as the ability to navigate complex situations with grace and ease.

In order to start my own businesses, I have had to go through a number of challenges and obstacles. However, the experience that I have gained from these has enabled me to be valuable in serving as a director, coach, adviser or mentor. As many successful people have noted, it is often difficult to see how all of the pieces fit together until you look back on your life and connect the dots. As Steve Jobs famously noted, "You can't connect the dots looking forward; you can only connect them looking backwards." This statement holds for many successful professionals who find their life paths unfolding unpredictably, yet ultimately leading them towards fulfilling careers. In the light of Steve's statement, I have come to understand the unpredictability of my journey and the impact it has had on me today. I recognize that my

experiences are not unique and that everyone faces their own set of challenges in life. Big or small, mighty or feeble, we all have our own fights and challenges. Ultimately, though, I trust that everything will fall into place and that the dots will eventually connect in ways that make sense. So, like everyone else's lives, mine has been marked by its share of ups-and-downs but it is through these challenges that we gain valuable skills and insights necessary to achieve our goals.

Despite the inherent unpredictability of life, what is most significant to me is acknowledging my humble beginnings and recognizing my roots. This has greatly influenced my values, character and work ethic. Understanding that there will always be individuals who are hungrier and more driven than me, and that failure to seize the day leads to regret, has instilled a particular mindset within me from an early age. My ancestors' stories and those of my grandparents have also contributed significantly toward shaping my educational priorities. Secondly, having some semblance of a plan is essential; while no two

people's plans will ever be identical, it is crucial to know your desired direction in order to make informed decisions about how best to proceed towards your goals. As long as you put some kind of destination in Google Maps, you will get there even if you detour or miss a turn because Google Maps will reroute. I was fortunate to have at least a rough sense of direction when embarking on this journey so as not to lose sight of my desired destination.

My strong adaptability is largely attributed to my upbringing as an immigrant and unique health circumstances, setting me apart from the majority. While many individuals may succumb to low self-esteem when faced with bullying or perceived inferiority, I instead harnessed these experiences as motivation for hard work. Rather than attributing my differences to blame or inadequacy, I recognize that stepping outside of one's comfort zone and embracing adversity is what makes life more dynamic.

The Growth Mindset

Embracing a growth mindset is not merely a choice; it's a profound commitment to shaping our destiny with unwavering optimism and resilience. It's about seeing the silver lining in every cloud and transforming challenges into stepping stones toward success. This mentality, reminiscent of the sage advice my parents once imparted, resonates deeply within me – the notion that true victory lies not merely in triumphing over adversaries, but in the strength forged through adversity. It's akin to inheriting a legacy of resilience, where each setback is but a fleeting obstacle on the path to greatness. I may not be where I want to end up today, but by working hard and believing in myself, one day I will be.

With this mindset firmly entrenched, success ceases to be a distant dream but a tangible reality within grasp. It's about not just crossing the finish line but doing so with a resounding victory, leaving no doubt in anyone's mind about your

capabilities. It's about aiming not just to win, but to excel – to surpass expectations and redefine the boundaries of possibility. Like a skilled athlete visualizing the finish line long before the race begins, we must envision our goals with unwavering clarity, knowing that victory is not just a possibility but inevitability.

In embracing this growth mindset, we liberate ourselves from the shackles of self-doubt and external judgment. We no longer fret over the opinions of others or dwell on past mistakes; instead, we focus our energies on the present moment, giving our absolute best in everything we do. It's about seizing every opportunity with confidence and optimism, knowing that each challenge is but a chance to grow and evolve.

Hence, it is important that we embrace the growth mindset wholeheartedly, for it is the key that unlocks the door to boundless success and fulfillment. Let us approach every endeavor with unwavering conviction, knowing that victory is not just a possibility but our birthright. For in the journey of life, it's not about how fast we run or how high we climb, but the steadfastness of our

resolve and the unwavering belief in our ability to run farther and climb higher. Let us march forward with heads held high, for the world is ours to conquer if only we dare to believe.

A Vision for the Future

In my vision for the future, I will formally dedicate myself to being a mentor and coach for business executives, specifically those in C-level positions or striving to be in those positions. My goal is to help them enhance their skills as CFOs or CEOs and overcome obstacles they may be facing in their careers. I will be here to help them become more effective and impactful leaders so they can scale their businesses. Furthermore, I can formally coach those who are facing crossroads in their careers, whether to stay in the same job or explore new opportunities. I want to provide guidance and support that will enable all to discover their purpose and feel more fulfilled in their work. My programs will help clients develop a process for themselves that they can take with them as a lifelong compass.

I believe that my own experience as an entrepreneur, operator, global investor and board member has given me valuable insights into the challenges faced by high achievers today. By sharing these insights with others and providing them with the tools they need to succeed, I hope to make a meaningful contribution to the business community.

Ultimately, my vision is not just about helping individuals achieve their career goals but also about creating a culture of growth and learning within organizations. By promoting a growth mindset and encouraging continuous learning and development, we can create more resilient businesses that are better equipped to adapt to change and thrive in today's fast-paced world.

My vision for the future is one of empowerment, growth, and reflection. Through my educational initiative for business executives, I hope to inspire others to reach their full potential while contributing to the long-term success of organizations around the world. It is my greatest aspiration that the seeds planted through this initiative will blossom into a legacy of empowered

individuals who lead with integrity, innovate with purpose, and uplift others as they climb. Most importantly, my programs can help many others believe they can write a biography that they can be proud of and inspire their readers.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Hong Kong born Anthony Tse is a global citizen who believes in going all in with passion and hard work to pursue freedom, purpose and dreams. After facing two near death experiences at a young age, he has learned to live a life of no regrets. As an immigrant and first-generation college graduate, Tse pivots from a career in finance to education, and from being an employee to two-time entrepreneur.

Today, he is an independent director of funds, and to business owners, a mentor that manages his own wealth. Tse loves coaching working professionals facing crossroads in their careers. He is also dedicated to helping senior executives become better leaders. Despite his busy schedule, he is highly involved in the upbringing of his children and enjoys the freedom to take full control of his schedule to focus on things he truly values.

BREAKING THE GLASS CEILING

"Breaking the Glass Ceiling: An Insider Memoir" takes readers on a transformative journey through the life of an ordinary individual who defied the odds to achieve success. From the thriving city of Hong Kong to navigating the complexities of immigrant life in the United States, the author shares candidly the challenges and triumphs that shaped his path.

More than just a story of professional achievement, "Breaking the Glass Ceiling" is a testament to the power of perseverance, the importance of embracing opportunities, and the transformative potential of taking calculated risks. Through the author's inspiring journey, readers are encouraged to break free from the confines of societal expectations and pursue their own dreams with courage and determination.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Anthony Tse is a global citizen who believes in going all in with passion and hard work to pursue freedom, purpose and dreams. After facing two near death experiences at a young age, he has learned to live a life of no regrets. As an immigrant and first-generation college graduate, Tse pivots from a career in finance to education, and from being an employee to a two-time entrepreneur.

Today, he is an independent director of funds, and to business owners, a mentor that manages his own wealth. Tse loves coaching working professionals facing crossroads in their careers. He is also dedicated to helping senior executives become better leaders. Despite his busy schedule, he is highly involved in the upbringing of his children and enjoys the freedom to take full control of his schedule to focus on things he truly values.